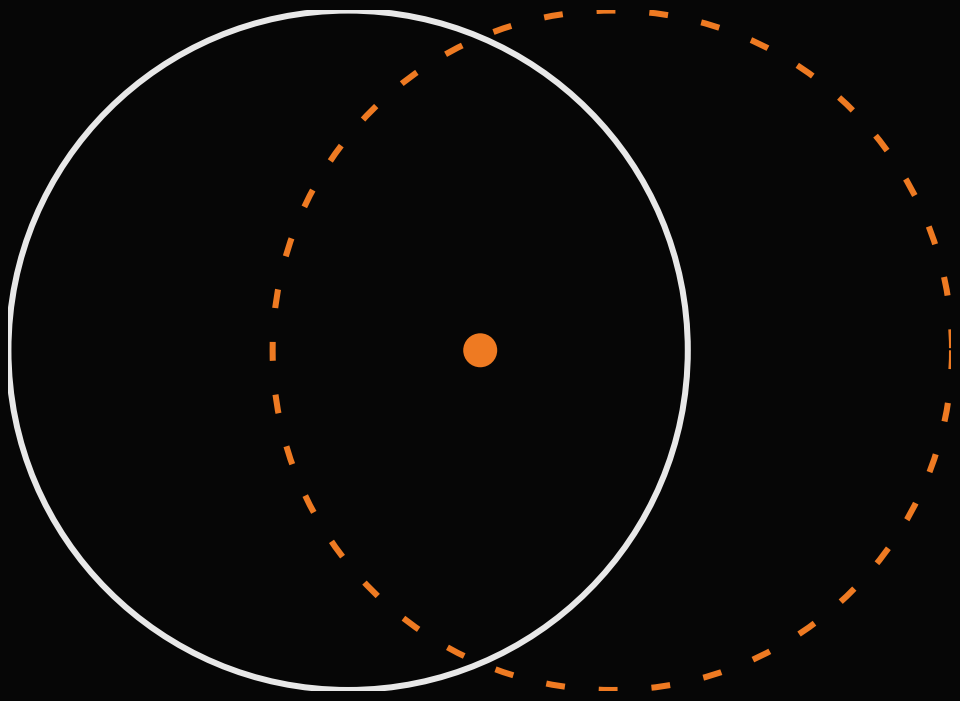
A DOCTORAL THESIS · NEON GENESIS EVANGELION · 1995–2021

OSMOSIS AGAINST LYSIS

浸透と溶解

The Absolute Terror Field, Thalassal Eschatology, and the Ethics of the Semipermeable Self in Hideaki Anno's Neon Genesis Evangelion (1995–2021)



25 SEPTEMBER 2026

THE WALL OF THE HEART IS THE LIGHT OF THE HEART

FRONT MATTER

Abstract

This thesis argues that the philosophical core of Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (television, 1995–96; *The End of Evangelion*, 1997; *Rebuild of Evangelion*, 2007–2021) lies neither in its Judeo-Christian iconography, which its makers disclaimed as ornament, nor in its psychoanalytic scaffolding, which its episode titles openly advertise, but in a rigorously elaborated ontology of the boundary. The corpus's central device, the Absolute Terror Field, is designated within the diegesis both as the "wall of the heart" (*kokoro no kabe*) and as the "light of the heart" (*kokoro no hikari*). That double designation condenses a problem that runs from Anaximander's *apeiron* through Schopenhauer's porcupines and Freud's oceanic feeling to Levinas's critique of totality: whether the separateness of persons is the wound to be healed or the condition of anything worth healing.

Against the prevailing readings of the Human Instrumentality Project as either Gnostic apotheosis or infantile regression, I distinguish two structurally opposed models of communion that the corpus stages and adjudicates. The first, which I term *lysis*, is the rupture of the membrane into undifferentiated continuity; it gathers SEELE's eschatology together with the Gnostic pleroma, counterfeit Lurianic restoration, Ferenczi's "thalassal regressive trend," Bataille's continuity, and Clarke's Overmind, and it is realized on screen as the red sea of LCL. The second, *osmosis*, is exchange across a boundary that the exchange itself sustains; it is theorized here through Claude Bernard's *milieu intérieur*, Maturana and Varela's autopoiesis, Watsuji Tetsurō's ethics of *aidagara* (betweenness), Nishitani Keiji's circuminsessional field of śūnyatā, the Huayan net of Indra, and Bakhtin's polyphony of "unmerged" voices.

Reading the corpus stratigraphically — through its cosmogonic, semiotic, psychoanalytic, existential, sociohistorical, comparative, and medial layers — the thesis demonstrates that *Evangelion* alone among the works of speculative philosophy with which it is compared (Stapledon, Clarke, Lem, Ballard, Dick, Le Guin, Cordwainer Smith, the Strugatskys, Abe Kōbō, Tomino, Ōtomo, Oshii) carries the lytic consummation through to completion and then refuses it from within. Five original claims are advanced. First, the corpus replays the *Chaoskampf* of *Enūma Eliš* and Genesis 1 as a separation that need not kill: the Children selected by the "Marduk" Institute bid the maternal deep farewell rather than slaying it. Second, humanity's descent from Lilith, whose defining act in the *Alphabet of Ben Sira* is refusal, grounds a "Lilithic axiom" replayed in Rei's rejection of Gendo and fulfilled in Asuka's closing *kimochi warui*, which Kristeva's theory of abjection identifies as the founding affect of re-individuation. Third, SEELE's program of evolving an "incomplete colonial organism" into a "complete single organism" commits a category error that evolutionary biology exposes, confusing the multicellular organism with the primordial soup. Fourth, the corpus's relation to its imported religious signs is itself osmotic, so that the text's form of borrowing reproduces its

theme. Fifth, animation, a medium built from stacked transparent membranes, is uniquely equipped to think a semipermeable self, as the contrast between the lytic rupture of *The End of Evangelion*'s live-action sequence and the osmotic passage into photographed Ube in *Thrice Upon a Time* demonstrates.

The thesis concludes by formalizing an *osmotic humanism* in definitions, axioms, propositions, and replies to objections. Its ethical kernel is that love is possible only where refusal remains possible, and that the "gospel" the corpus finally announces is the good news of separateness understood not as the Fall but as the firmament.

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FRONT MATTER

Note on Corpus, Transliteration, and Citation

The corpus is read as a single, internally divided text spanning 1995 to 2021, cited by the abbreviations below; ancillary materials are marked as such and never bear an interpretive claim alone.

Corpus

The primary corpus comprises four bodies of work. (1) The television series *Shin Seiki Evangelion* (TV), twenty-six episodes directed by Anno Hideaki for Gainax and Tatsunoko Production and broadcast on TV Tokyo from 4 October 1995 to 27 March 1996, together with the director's cuts of Episodes 21–24 prepared for the video release and designated 21′–24′. (2) *Shin Seiki Evangelion Gekijōban: Shito Shinsei* (*Evangelion: Death and Rebirth*, D&R, March 1997), a recapitulative montage coupled with the opening of the reworked finale. (3) *Shin Seiki Evangelion Gekijōban: Air / Magokoro o, Kimi ni* (*The End of Evangelion*, EoE, 19 July 1997), whose two parts function as Episodes 25′ and 26′. (4) The *Rebuild of Evangelion* tetralogy produced by Anno's Studio Khara: *Evangelion: 1.0 You Are* (*Not*) *Alone* (*Evangerion Shin Gekijōban: Jo*, 2007), *2.0 You Can* (*Not*) *Advance* (*Ha*, 2009), *3.0 You Can* (*Not*) *Redo* (*Q*, 2012), and *Evangelion: 3.0+1.0 Thrice Upon a Time* (*Shin Evangerion Gekijōban*, 8 March 2021; hereafter *3.0+1.0*). Theatrical versions are cited throughout; the revised home-video versions (1.11, 2.22, 3.33, 3.0+1.01) are consulted only where a variant bears on the argument.

Ancillary materials — Sadamoto Yoshiyuki's manga adaptation (serialized 1994–2013), published scenarios, the original series proposal, theatrical programs (notably the booklet issued with EoE and known from its cover as the *Red Cross Book*), and the data files of licensed games — supply details absent from the animated text, including several on which fan exegesis depends, such as the derivation of Unit-01 from Lilith. They are treated as a stratum of the work's reception rather than as authorial fiat, flagged at each use, and never adduced as the sole support for a reading.

Episodes, names, and diegetic terms

Episodes are cited by number. Each carries a Japanese title and a separate English title printed on the title card; the two often diverge, and the divergence is frequently itself an argument. Episode 16, *Shi ni itaru yamai, soshite* ("The Sickness unto Death, and…"), is subtitled "Splitting of the Breast"; Episode 26, *Sekai no chūshin de ai o sakenda kemono* ("The Beast That Shouted 'I' at the Heart of the World"), is subtitled "Take Care of Yourself." Both titles are given at first mention.

Japanese is romanized in modified Hepburn, with macrons for long vowels (*Watsuji Tetsurō*, *sayōnara*), except in place-names naturalized in English (Tokyo, Kobe) and the fictional Tokyo-3. Japanese names of real persons appear family name first; the director's name appears in Western order in the title and abstract, following the convention of the work's international distribution. Characters are named by given name in the forms fixed by the English localization (Shinji, Gendo, Toji), without macrons. Diegetic terms appear in their established English forms — Angel for *shito* (literally "apostle"), Children for the pilots, Absolute Terror Field (A.T. Field), Human Instrumentality Project for *jinrui hokan keikaku* — and the Japanese is supplied wherever the English conceals an argument, as it repeatedly does. The first three Rebuild films spell the title with the obsolete kana ヱ and ヲ (ヱヴァンゲリヲン); the fourth restores the standard orthography (エヴァンゲリオン). The detour is analyzed in Chapter Seven.

Dialogue and translation

Dialogue is paraphrased in English; short phrases on which an argument turns are given in romanized Japanese with a gloss. Translations are the author's own. No subtitle track or dub is treated as authoritative, because the English versions diverge substantially and consequentially. The rendering of Kaworu's *suki tte koto sa* (Episode 24) as a declaration of love in one English version and of liking in another is a case in point, since Chapter Four turns precisely on the difference between an affect that fuses and one that regards. Song lyrics are described, never quoted.

Citation

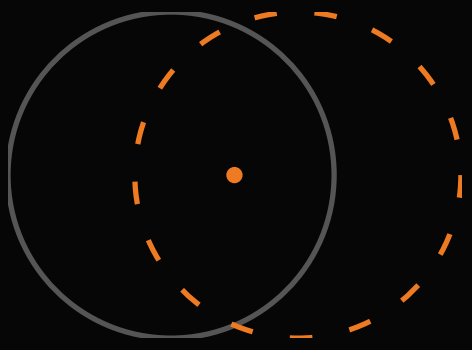
Sources are cited author–date by first publication in the original language, with a second date for a translation where both matter. Ancient and scriptural texts follow conventional reference systems: Diels–Kranz numbering for the Presocratics, book, chapter, and verse for the Bible (English quotations from the Authorized Version), tractate and folio for the Babylonian Talmud, tablet and line for *Enūma Eliš*. Pagination is omitted because editions and translations vary; quotations should be verified against the standard editions — the *Standard Edition* for Freud, the *Gesamtausgabe* for Heidegger, the Iwanami collected works for Watsuji and Nishida. Statements attributed to production staff circulate largely through translated interviews, convention transcripts, and secondary compilations; they are reported as attributed and weighed as evidence of production and reception, not as interpretive verdicts. This thesis was composed without archival verification of editions; release dates, episode assignments, and ancillary details should be checked against the current Khara filmography before citation in published work.

INTRODUCTION

00

序論

The Cruel Angel's Thesis



Neon Genesis Evangelion is a sustained inquiry into the ontological status of the boundary between persons, and its answer — reached only after that boundary has been abolished on screen — is that the membrane is not the wound of existence but its organ. This introduction situates the inquiry in the conjuncture of 1995, formulates the problem of the "wall of the heart" in the corpus's own terms, defines the opposition between lysis and osmosis on which the thesis rests, sets out a stratigraphic method, surveys the critical literature, and outlines the argument.

The conjuncture of 1995

Evangelion first aired on 4 October 1995, at the close of a year in which the governing fictions of postwar Japan — safety, prosperity, and a carefully administered innocence — failed in rapid sequence. On 17 January the Great Hanshin–Awaji earthquake killed more than six thousand people in and around Kobe, exposing both the fragility of the engineered city and the slowness of the state that administered it. On 20 March members of Aum Shinrikyō released sarin on five trains of the Tokyo subway, killing more than a dozen people and injuring thousands; among the perpetrators were university-trained scientists, and the sect's eschatology had been assembled from the Book of Revelation, Hindu and Buddhist yogic traditions, Nostradamus, and the iconography of televised science fiction. The collapse of the asset bubble at the start of the decade had already opened what would be called the "lost decade," and on 15 August the fiftieth anniversary of the surrender was marked by Prime Minister Murayama Tomiichi's statement of "deep remorse" for colonial rule and aggression. It would be difficult to design a more exact setting for a narrative in which a fortified city rebuilds itself after every assault, an official account of catastrophe (the meteorite said to have caused the "Second Impact") conceals a human experiment, a secret council of old men plans the end of the world according to a scripture of its own, and children are sent to fight a war the adults will not explain.

The personal conjuncture was no less acute. Anno had emerged from a depression of several years following *Fushigi no Umi no Nadia* (*Nadia: The Secret of Blue Water*, 1990–91). In a statement issued before the broadcast — circulated in English as "What were we trying to make here?" — he described the new series as the work of a man who had spent four years running away and had resolved at least not to run, and as an attempt to put the whole of himself on film (Anno 1995). The phrase would become the protagonist's mantra: *nigecha dame da*, "I mustn't run away." The sociologist Ōsawa Masachi would soon read Aum as the terminal symptom of an "age of fiction" in which the fictional had begun to demand enactment (Ōsawa 1996); Miyadai Shinji, in the year of the attack, urged his readers to renounce apocalyptic longing and to live the "endless everyday" (Miyadai 1995). *Evangelion* stages both positions and, only after exhausting the first, chooses a transfigured version of the second.

The coincidence of private and collective catastrophe has licensed two dominant ways of reading the work. The first treats it as symptom, decoding the text back into its author's depression or its decade's malaise; the second treats it as scripture, decoding its esoteric

vocabulary forward into a concealed cosmology. Both treat the text as a surface over a hidden content. This thesis treats it instead as an argument — conducted in images, sound, and narrative structure as much as in dialogue — about a single question, which the corpus poses with increasing explicitness across twenty-six years.

The problem of the wall

The question is announced before it can be understood. The opening theme, "Zankoku na tenshi no tēze" ("A Cruel Angel's Thesis"; lyrics by Oikawa Neko, sung by Takahashi Yōko), reportedly written from planning documents rather than finished footage, borrows the German *These* for its title and enjoins its boy to become a myth. Taken literally, the title asks what thesis the Angels advance. The Angels (*shito*, "apostles," glossed ANGEL on the title cards) are not aliens: the characteristic wave pattern of one is found to match human genetic information at 99.89 percent, and the last takes human form and human speech. Read in sequence, they compose a graduated phenomenology of contact: bombardment (Sachiel, Ramiel); infiltration of the city's computational nervous system (Ireul); absorption into an interior void (Leliel); psychic violation (Arael); physical fusion (Armisael); and, finally, friendship (Tabris). Each stage presses the same claim — that communion requires the destruction of the boundary — and each Angel is "cruel" precisely because it seeks communion by breach. The cruel angel's thesis is lysis. Its antithesis is not isolation but a boundary that permits passage, which this thesis names osmosis.

The corpus's name for the boundary undergoes a threefold expansion that traces the arc of its thought. In the early episodes the Absolute Terror Field is a military datum: an impenetrable barrier that renders conventional weapons useless and that the Evangelions must "neutralize" (*chūwa suru*) with fields of their own — a verb borrowed, significantly, from acid–base chemistry. In Episode 24 Kaworu gives it a psychic definition: every being possesses a sacred and inviolable domain, the "light of the heart" (*kokoro no hikari*), which the Lilin — humanity — know as the "wall of the heart" (*kokoro no kabe*) that everyone bears. In EoE the definition becomes ontological: when an inverted field is generated at planetary scale, bodies lose the form the field had sustained and collapse into the orange fluid, LCL, that fills the Evangelions' cockpits. The A.T. Field is thus at once weapon, wound, and form. What keeps the other out keeps the self in; the pain of the one is the price of the other. The problem this thesis addresses follows: whether the separateness of persons is the wound to be healed or the condition of anything worth healing.

The problem has a lineage, and the corpus knows it. Schopenhauer's porcupines, who huddle for warmth and are driven apart by their quills until they find a tolerable distance, furnish the "hedgehog's dilemma" (*yamaarashi no jirenma*) that Ritsuko glosses early in the series and that gives Episode 4 its English title. Freud's "oceanic feeling" — the sense of limitless union that Romain Rolland proposed as the source of religious sentiment — furnishes the red sea of the finale. Between these poles stand Anaximander's account of individuation as an injustice paid for by dissolution, Nietzsche's Dionysian shattering of the *principium individuationis*, Ferenczi's "thalassal regressive trend," Bataille's nostalgia for lost continuity, Levinas's insistence that separation is the precondition of ethics, and Watsuji Tetsurō's

derivation of the human being (*ningen*) from the space "between" (*aida*). The corpus assembles these not as allusions but as positions in a dispute — and it adjudicates.

Lysis and osmosis

Two terms from the physiology of the cell organize the adjudication. *Lysis* (λύσις: loosening, dissolution, but also release and redemption) designates the rupture of a membrane and the consequent loss of the gradient that distinguished inside from outside; a lysed cell does not join its surroundings, it ceases to be a cell. *Osmosis* (from ὠσμός, "thrust") designates the passage of a solvent across a semipermeable membrane down a gradient of concentration. The Abbé Nollet observed it in 1748, as water forced its way through a pig's bladder into spirits of wine; Henri Dutrochet named it in the 1820s; Wilhelm Pfeffer measured its pressure in 1877; J. H. van 't Hoff gave it thermodynamic form in 1886. Three features of the phenomenon carry the argument. Osmosis requires a membrane: without the partition there is mixing, not osmosis. It requires difference: the flow is driven by a disparity between the sides and ceases when the disparity is abolished. And it is bounded in a way lysis is not: when a membrane is too weak for the pressure it bears, the result is not deeper osmosis but rupture. Osmosis models a communion that sustains the partners it connects; lysis, a communion that consumes them.

The Human Instrumentality Project — whether conceived as SEELE's artificial evolution of an "incomplete colonial organism" into a "complete single organism" or as Gendo's private rite of reunion with his vanished wife — is a program of lysis, and the red sea of LCL is both its product and its image. The corpus's refusals of that program — the television finale's therapeutic dialogue, EoE's return to the beach, *3.0+1.0*'s passage from animation into the photographed world — do not return to the closed cell of the isolated individual. Each restores the membrane in order to reopen exchange across it. The work's gospel (*euangelion*, "good news") is therefore the good news of separateness understood not as the Fall but as the firmament: the partition that, in the first chapter of Genesis, makes room for a world.

Method: a stratigraphic reading

The Geofront — the vast spherical cavity beneath Tokyo-3 in which NERV's pyramid stands, itself the upper level of a descending sequence of Central and Terminal Dogma at whose floor a giant hangs crucified — supplies the method. The corpus is layered rather than integrated. Its Christian and Kabbalistic surface, its psychoanalytic episode titles, its existentialist dialogue, its science-fictional mechanisms, and its self-reflexive formal devices do not form a system; they lie upon one another like sediments deposited at different times from different sources, and meaning is generated at their interfaces. The thesis therefore reads stratigraphically. Its model is Maruyama Masao's account of the "ancient stratum" (*kosō*) of Japanese historical consciousness, later reformulated as a *basso ostinato* (*shitsuyō teion*): a persistent low register that is not itself a doctrine but modulates every doctrine imported over it (Maruyama 1972). Maruyama located that register in a sensibility of spontaneous,

successive becoming — *tsugitsugi ni nariyuku ikioi*, the momentum of things becoming one after another. The imported eschatologies of consummation in *Evangelion* are, as later chapters show, bent by just such a register into cosmologies of renewal and repetition, of which the very premise of a "Rebuild" is the formal expression.

The method differs from both dominant hermeneutics. Against decoding by authorial intention, it adopts Wimsatt and Beardsley's warning (1946) as a rule and treats staff statements — including the often-quoted remark attributed to assistant director Tsurumaki Kazuya that the Christian imagery was chosen for its exotic visual appeal rather than for any doctrinal meaning — as data about production, not limits on signification. Against decoding by esoteric key, it follows Eco in locating interpretive authority in the *intentio operis*, the coherence a text exhibits and can be shown to sustain (Eco 1990). Its criterion is structural: a borrowed sign counts when its morphology — its shape, function, and position within a system — recurs in the corpus's own logic, whatever its borrowers believed. Chapter Two argues that this is also the corpus's own relation to its sources.

The thesis descends through seven strata — cosmogonic, semiotic, psychoanalytic, existential, sociohistorical, comparative, and medial — and excavates each with the disciplines proper to it: comparative mythology and biblical criticism, the history of religions, psychoanalysis, phenomenology and Japanese philosophy, the sociology of the Japanese 1990s, the history of speculative fiction, and the theory of animation. An eighth chapter takes a core sample through all seven and formalizes what it finds.

State of the field

Criticism of *Evangelion* is voluminous, uneven, and divided by language, discipline, and generation. Its first Japanese readers treated the work as a diagnosis of its moment. Takekuma Kentarō's interview volumes *Parano Evangelion* and *Schizo Evangelion* (1997), whose titles echo Asada Akira's opposition of the paranoid and the schizoid subject (Asada 1984), preserved Anno's account of the production and its collapse. Kotani Mari's *Seibo Evangelion* (1997) read the series through feminist SF criticism as a meditation on the monstrous maternal body. Ōsawa (1996, 2008) and Miyadai (1995) placed it within the sociology of post-Aum Japan; Azuma Hiroki (2001) made it the hinge between the consumption of grand narratives and the "database" consumption of detachable character elements; Saitō Tamaki (2000) took Rei and Asuka as paradigms of the "beautiful fighting girl" and her phallic function; and Uno Tsunehiro (2008) indicted it as the origin of *sekai-kei* ("world-type") fiction, in which the fate of the world is short-circuited through an adolescent couple without passing through society. In English, Susan Napier (2001, 2002, 2005) situated the work within anime's apocalyptic and identity-dissolving modes; Thomas Lamarre (2009) supplied a theory of anime's layered image that Chapter Seven extends; and Mariana Ortega (2007) offered a sustained psychoanalytic-feminist reading of its mothers. Beyond the academy, an immense body of fan exegesis, much of it built on the ancillary materials, has reconstructed the narrative's hidden chronology with philological tenacity.

Five lacunae define the contribution of this thesis. First, the debate over the religious iconography is stalled between a decorative reading that dismisses it and an esoteric one that

over-decodes it; neither explains why the borrowed signs work as they do. Second, psychoanalytic readings characterize Instrumentality as regression without asking what formal character the refusal of regression must have if it is not to become mere repression. Third, the Japanese philosophy of betweenness — Watsuji, Nishida, Nishitani — has rarely been brought to bear, although the corpus's vocabulary of *hito*, *ningen*, and *kokoro* invites it at every turn. Fourth, the biological and thermodynamic dimensions of the imagery — its liquids, membranes, and fantasies of "evolution" — have been treated as set dressing rather than as arguments. Fifth, no account yet integrates the 2021 conclusion of the Rebuild tetralogy, which retroactively reorganizes the whole, into a single theory of the corpus.

Plan of the work

Chapter One, "Tiamat's Children," excavates the cosmogonic stratum. It reads Genesis 1 and *Enūma Eliš* as narratives of creation by separation, argues that the Children selected by the "Marduk" Institute reenact the division of the maternal deep without its murder, interprets Third Impact as an uncreation modeled on the Flood and Instrumentality as a counterfeit of Lurianic *tikkun*, and draws on origin-of-life research, Claude Bernard's *milieu intérieur*, and the theory of major evolutionary transitions to show that SEELE's program is biologically a de-transition: the reduction of an organism to a soup.

Chapter Two, "The Borrowed Apocalypse," addresses the semiotic stratum. Between decoration and decoding it proposes a model of osmotic transmission, in which imported signs cross into the text carrying their morphology while their doctrine is filtered out. It reads the Lilith of the *Alphabet of Ben Sira*, whose defining act is refusal, as the source of a "Lilithic axiom" governing the corpus's ethics, and identifies the Gnostic pair of Simon Magus and Helen–Ennoia as the unacknowledged template of Gendo's pursuit of Yui.

Chapter Three, "The Thalassal Complex," traces the psychoanalytic stratum from Freud and Ferenczi through Rank, Klein, Winnicott, Lacan, Kristeva, and R. D. Laing, and from Doi Takeo's *amae* to Kawai Hayao's "maternal society." It argues that the corpus relocates the separating function from the Father's prohibition to the Other's refusal, and that Asuka's closing *kimochi warui* is the founding affect of re-individuation.

Chapter Four, "The Wall of the Heart," reconstructs the existential stratum: Schopenhauer and Nietzsche; the Kierkegaardian forms of despair that organize the principal characters; Heidegger, Sartre, Hegel and Kojève, and Levinas; and, decisively, Watsuji's *aidagara*, Nishida's *basho*, Nishitani's *śūnyatā*, and the Huayan net of Indra, which together supply the concept of a relation that constitutes its relata without dissolving them.

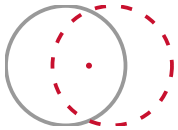
Chapter Five, "The Instrumentality of Mankind," reads the sociohistorical stratum: the Cordwainer Smith stories from which the project takes its English name; Teilhard and Clarke; the technocratic institutions of NERV and SEELE; Aum Shinrikyō, the "endless everyday," and the debates over *otaku*, *hikikomori*, and *sekai-kei*; and the child soldier as the figure of an adult world's abdication.

Chapter Six, "The Beast That Shouted 'I'," places the corpus in the constellation of speculative philosophy, distinguishing a lytic canon (Stapledon, Clarke, Bear, Dick, Tomino, Ōtomo, Oshii, Gibson) from an osmotic counter-canon (Lem and Tarkovsky, Le Guin, the

Strugatskys, Keyes, Huxley), and argues that *Evangelion* alone consummates lysis and then refuses it from within.

Chapter Seven, "The Medium Is the Membrane," argues that cel animation — an image composed of stacked transparent sheets — is uniquely equipped to think a semipermeable self, and that the corpus's two conclusions, the lytic rupture of EoE's live-action sequence and the osmotic passage into photographed Ube in *3.0+1.0*, enact at the level of the medium what their narratives enact at the level of the person.

Chapter Eight, "Osmosis Against Lysis," formalizes the argument *more geometrico* — in definitions, axioms, propositions, and replies to objections — as an osmotic humanism whose kernel is that love is possible only where refusal remains possible. The Conclusion returns to the word with which the television series ends and which the final film makes its slogan: *sayōnara*, whose etymology — "if it must be so" — contains the ethics of the membrane entire.



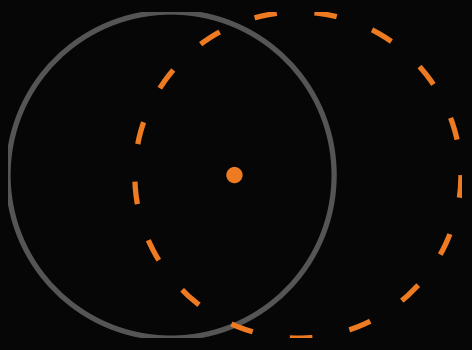
CHAPTER ONE

01

第一章

Tiamat's Children

Cosmogony, Uncreation, and the First Membrane



The cosmogonic stratum of *Evangelion* is organized by a single opposition — creation as separation against apocalypse as the undoing of separation — and the corpus sides, against its own antagonists, with creation. This chapter reconstructs the opposition through five deposits: Presocratic speculation on the unlimited, the biblical and Babylonian narratives of creation by division, the Flood as uncreation, Lurianic Kabbalah, and the modern biology of the membrane.

1.1 The water and the unlimited

Western philosophy begins, in Aristotle's retrospective account, with the claim of Thales that the principle (*archē*) of all things is water (*Metaphysics* A.3, 983b). Anaximander replaced water with the *apeiron*, the unlimited or indeterminate, and bequeathed the one sentence of his that survives in something like his own words (DK 12 B1): the things that are pass away into that from which they came to be, "according to necessity; for they pay penalty and retribution to one another for their injustice, according to the ordinance of time." Two readings of the fragment define the poles of the present argument. For the young Nietzsche, it expresses the pessimistic conviction that individual existence is a guilt — an emancipation from the eternal that must be expiated by dissolution (Nietzsche 1873). For Heidegger, the "injustice" (*adikia*) is a disjunction (*Un-fug*) in which what lingers insists on persisting and sets itself against its neighbors, and the "retribution" (*tisis*) is not punishment but regard (*Ruch*): the lingering beings let order and consideration belong to one another (Heidegger 1946). On the first reading, separateness is a debt payable only by death; on the second, it is a disjunction healed not by abolition but by reciprocal regard.

SEELE is a Nietzschean reader of Anaximander without Nietzsche's tragic affirmation. Its eschatology treats the plurality of humankind as a fault — a condition of sin, incompleteness, and impasse — and its remedy is return to the undifferentiated. The Japanese name of the project makes the axiology explicit: *hokan*, rendered "instrumentality," means supplementation or completion, and presupposes a lack. The red sea of LCL into which EoE dissolves humanity, which the film's dialogue calls the soup of life, is the *apeiron* rendered in pigment: without limit, without determination, and — this is the point — without anyone in it. The alternative reading of the fragment, in which the injustice of individuation is answered by the regard beings grant one another across their separateness, is the first appearance in this thesis of what will be called osmosis.

1.2 Creation as division: Genesis, *Enūma Eliš*, and the Marduk Institute

The priestly account of creation in Genesis 1 opens on a deep (*tehom*) over which darkness lies and a divine wind moves, and proceeds almost entirely by division. The verb *hivdil*, "separated" (root b-d-l), occurs five times in the chapter (vv. 4, 6, 7, 14, 18): light is divided from darkness, the waters above from the waters below, day from night. The instrument of the second division is the *raqia'* ("firmament"), a noun from a root meaning to beat out or

hammer thin, as metal is beaten into foil. The first made thing in the biblical cosmos is thus a thin sheet interposed in the waters — a membrane. Dry land appears when the lower waters are gathered; living kinds are made "after their kind." Creation is the articulation of an undifferentiated deep by partitions, and holiness (*qodesh*, "set apart") is its liturgical echo: the Havdalah rite that closes the Sabbath blesses the God who separates holy from profane, light from darkness, the seventh day from the six. Mary Douglas's analysis of the Levitical purity system as a grammar of classificatory boundaries, in which dirt is matter out of place and holiness is wholeness kept distinct (Douglas 1966), extends the principle from cosmos to culture and anticipates the theory of abjection taken up in Chapter Three.

Hermann Gunkel's *Schöpfung und Chaos* (1895) established that the biblical *tehom* is etymologically cognate with Tiamat, the primordial salt sea of the Babylonian *Enūma Eliš*, and that traces of a combat between a storm god and the sea (*Chaoskampf*) survive in the Psalms, Isaiah, and Job, where Rahab is cut and Leviathan's heads are crushed. *Enūma Eliš* opens on a state before names in which Apsû, the sweet waters, and Tiamat, the salt waters, mingle their waters together as one. The primordial condition of the Babylonian cosmos is, precisely, a mixture of waters — the condition that Third Impact restores. Creation begins when Marduk kills Tiamat, splits her body in two like a fish for drying, and raises half of it as the sky; he then draws a bar across it, posts guards, and orders them not to let her waters escape (Tablet IV, 137–140). The first firmament is made of the mother's own body, and it is a guarded membrane holding back a sea. Humanity is then formed from the blood of the slain rebel Kingu, to bear the labor of the gods (Tablet VI). In *Evangelion*, too, humans are children of blood: the Lilin descend from Lilith, whose blood is the LCL into which they return.

The corpus names this stratum. The body that selects the pilots is the Marduk Institute, a name the series never glosses and eventually exposes as a front: an investigation in the second half of the series discovers that all 108 of its affiliated companies are paper entities under NERV's control. (Whether the number, which is also the canonical count of the passions, *bonnō*, in Japanese Buddhism, is deliberate cannot be established.) The Children are thus Marduks, chosen to fight the powers of the deep; but they fight from inside the maternal body, suspended in amniotic fluid within machines that contain their mothers' souls. The decisive difference between the Babylonian myth and its Japanese reenactment lies in the outcome. Marduk's cosmos requires Tiamat's death; the Children's requires only her farewell. Asuka does not kill the mother in Unit-02 but recognizes her; Shinji does not slay the mother in Unit-01 but lets her go. This is the first of the thesis's original claims: *Evangelion* replays the *Chaoskampf* as a separation that need not kill.

The Angels complicate the scheme in a way that confirms it. They are not monsters of chaos but siblings: the characteristic wave pattern of one matches human genetic information at 99.89 percent, and humanity is eventually identified as itself the eighteenth Angel. The war is fratricidal, a contest between the progeny of Adam and the progeny of Lilith for the inheritance of the earth, and each Angel's approach to the giant in Terminal Dogma is a return to the origin — an attempt to reverse the Genesis sequence and reunite what division created. The Angels are lytic returners; humanity survives by refusing return. The irony that powers the narrative is that the human institutions defending the partition are commanded by men who intend to dissolve it themselves.

1.3 The windows of heaven: the Flood as uncreation

The biblical firmament is not sealed. It has "windows" (*'arubbot*), and in the Flood narrative "the same day were all the fountains of the great deep broken up, and the windows of heaven were opened" (Gen 7:11). David Clines (1978) has read the Flood as an "uncreation": the waters above and the waters below, separated on the second day, are allowed to rejoin, and the world returns to the state of Genesis 1:2. The re-creation that follows — the waters recede, dry land appears, the living are again commanded to multiply — repeats the first creation, and it is sealed by a covenant whose sign, the bow in the cloud (Gen 9:13), is a promise that the partition will not be withdrawn again.

Third Impact is the Flood without the covenant. The windows are opened not by God but by men, and what pours through is not water but the dissolved substance of persons. The Evangelion that survives it is an ark: Unit-01, in which Yui chose to remain as enduring testimony that humanity had existed, departs the earth at the end of EoE as a vessel carrying one human soul into an indefinite future — less Noah's ark than a golden record launched into space. The Rebuild tetralogy multiplies the figure. Its principal warship, the *Wunder*, is associated with the preservation of terrestrial species, and Kaji, the corpus's gardener, is its Noah (the details are distributed across *3.0* and *3.0+1.0* and should be treated with caution). In *2.0*, the Children visit a facility attempting to restore life to seas rendered sterile and red by the Second Impact — a scene that inverts the Exodus, in which a red sea parts to open a way of liberation, and anticipates the final film's restoration of a blue one. EoE, by contrast, ends on a sea that remains red and unparted, beneath a sky marked with a band of red where the covenantal bow might have stood.

1.4 *Tzimtzum* and the counterfeit *tikkun*

The Kabbalah of Isaac Luria (1534–1572), reconstructed for modern scholarship by Gershom Scholem (1941), supplies the corpus's most rigorous cosmogonic foil. For Luria, creation begins not with emanation but with withdrawal: the Infinite (*Ein Sof*) contracts itself (*tzimtzum*) to vacate a space in which something other than God can exist. Into this space a line of light is drawn; vessels formed to contain it shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*); sparks of light fall into husks of matter; and the task of history is their repair (*tikkun*), performed through human deeds. Two features of the doctrine bear directly on *Evangelion*. First, *tzimtzum* is a divine A.T. Field: the first act of love is not effusion but limitation, the making of room. Second, *tikkun* is not a return into *Ein Sof*. It restores the broken vessels as articulated countenances (*partzufim*); it repairs the structure of difference rather than dissolving it.

Measured against Luria, SEELE's Instrumentality is an anti-*tzimtzum* and a counterfeit *tikkun*: it reads restoration as re-absorption, and would refill the vacated space with undifferentiated totality. The iconography confirms the source. The Sephirotic Tree of Life appears in the television opening and on the ceiling of Gendo's office — reportedly derived from the diagram in Athanasius Kircher's *Oedipus Aegyptiacus* (1652–54) — and in EoE it is formed in the sky by the mass-produced Evangelions, with Unit-01 at its center, as the configuration through which Third Impact is performed. Adam, the first Angel, is SEELE's

Adam Kadmon, the primordial human form to which history is to be returned. The Talmudic dictum that the son of David will not come until all the souls in the *Guf* — the treasury of unborn souls — have been exhausted (Yevamot 62a) makes messianic completion depend on every soul being born. EoE's opening of what it calls the Chamber of Guf, into which souls return, inverts the condition: completion is sought through un-birth.

1.5 The membrane at the origin of life

The biological stratum shows that this cosmology is not merely theological. Aleksandr Oparin (1924) and J. B. S. Haldane (1929) independently proposed that life arose in a primitive ocean enriched with organic compounds — Haldane's "hot dilute soup" — and Oparin located the decisive step in the formation of coacervate droplets, bounded concentrations of matter within the soup. On most contemporary accounts, compartmentalization belongs among the minimal conditions of life: a boundary concentrates reactions, sustains a gradient, and makes an individual. Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela's theory of autopoiesis (1972; 1980) generalizes the point. A living system is a network of processes that produces the components that produce it, including the boundary that constitutes it as a unity; the membrane is at once product and condition of the network it encloses. Organizationally closed and thermodynamically open, the cell is the paradigm of the osmotic self.

Claude Bernard gave the physiological form of the same insight in a sentence that serves as this thesis's third axiom: "La fixité du milieu intérieur est la condition de la vie libre, indépendante" — the constancy of the internal environment is the condition of free, independent life (Bernard 1878). Freedom, on this account, is not the abolition of the boundary but its achievement. Kaworu's declaration in Episode 24 that death is the only absolute freedom is SEELE's metaphysics in lyrical form, and Bernard is its refutation. René Quinton (1904) proposed that the internal milieu of animals preserves the saline composition of the ancient sea — that each organism carries the ocean within a membrane. The hypothesis is untenable in its literal form but exact as an image, and *Evangelion* realizes it: in his first sortie Shinji remarks that the LCL smells of blood. Instrumentality turns the inner sea outward; the osmotic organism keeps it within and lets it pass.

Walter Cannon's homeostasis (1932) and Erwin Schrödinger's account of life as the maintenance of order by the export of entropy (1944) complete the picture: the living is a system held far from equilibrium, and equilibrium is death. Freud named the psychic tendency to reduce excitation to zero, borrowing a term from Barbara Low, the Nirvana principle (1920). The red sea is Nirvana in the thermodynamic sense: a state in which all gradients have been abolished and nothing further can occur. The corpus stages this lesson in advance of the finale. In Episode 13, Ritsuko defeats Ireul, an Angel of self-organizing microorganisms that has invaded the MAGI, by accelerating its evolution until its terminal point, which proves to be self-destruction — the end of evolution, she concludes, is death. SEELE's "artificial evolution" of humankind is that program turned upon its authors.

1.6 The category error of the "complete single organism"

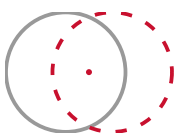
SEELE describes its goal as the artificial evolution of humanity, stalled as an incomplete colonial organism (*fukanzen na guntai*), into a complete single organism (*kanzen na tantai*). The biological vocabulary is precise enough to be judged. A *guntai* is a colony — a siphonophore such as the Portuguese man-of-war, or the alga *Volvox* — composed of individuals that are integrated but separable; a *tantai* is a unitary organism. SEELE's premise is that the multicellular organism surpasses the colony because its parts have been fused.

The premise is false, and its falsity is the third of the thesis's original claims. In Maynard Smith and Szathmáry's account of the major transitions in evolution (1995) — from replicating molecules to compartments, from prokaryotes to eukaryotes, from single cells to multicellular organisms, from solitary animals to colonies, from primate groups to human societies with language — entities that once replicated independently come to replicate only as parts of a larger whole. In none of these transitions do the parts dissolve their membranes. Multicellular organisms are made of cells that remain bounded, coordinate by chemical signaling and by gap junctions — regulated pores of connexin protein through which small molecules pass between adjacent cells — and suppress defection among their members, a suppression whose failure is called cancer. Where cells do fuse, as in the syncytiotrophoblast of the mammalian placenta, the fused tissue functions as a barrier: the principal interface between mother and fetus is a membrane that keeps two bloodstreams apart while letting them exchange. The one great site of fusion in mammalian development exists to secure the separation of mother and child.

Instrumentality is therefore not a transition but a de-transition. Its "complete single organism" is not an organism at all but a return below the first transition, to Haldane's soup. The last transition that Maynard Smith and Szathmáry describe — the emergence of human societies coordinated by language — has, moreover, already occurred, and it is osmotic: language is exchange across the boundaries of bodies that remain distinct. SEELE mistakes humanity's next step for one already taken, and proposes to take it by walking backward.

1.7 Conclusion: a new genesis is a new division

The cosmogonic stratum yields a consistent structure. In every source the corpus draws upon — Anaximander on Heidegger's reading, Genesis, *Enūma Eliš*, Luria, and the biology of the cell — a world exists by virtue of partitions, and the undoing of partitions is uncreation. The antagonists of *Evangelion* pursue uncreation under the names of evolution, salvation, and completion; its protagonists, at the end of every version of the story, choose a world. The title of the work, *Neon Genesis* — new genesis — should therefore be read with the force of Genesis 1: a new creation is a new division, and the good news the corpus announces is the firmament.



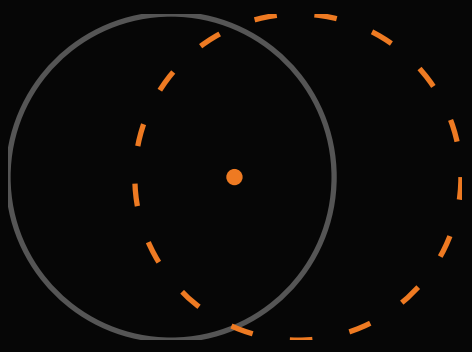
CHAPTER TWO

02

第二章

The Borrowed Apocalypse

Gnosis, Kabbalah, Lilith, and Osmotic Semiotics



The religious signs of *Evangelion* are neither ornament nor code: they cross into the text as solutes cross a membrane, carrying their morphology while their doctrine is retained on the far side. This chapter develops that model of osmotic transmission and tests it on the corpus's principal borrowings: the two trees of Eden, the figure of Lilith, the Gnostic drama of the imprisoned spark, and the paraphernalia of Christian eschatology.

2.1 Decoration, decoding, and a third way

The debate over the corpus's religious imagery is usually framed by a remark attributed to assistant director Tsurumaki Kazuya: that the Christian symbols were chosen because Christianity is exotic in Japan and made the show look distinctive, that no one on the staff was Christian, and that the imagery was not meant to carry special significance. The remark has licensed a decorative reading, which finds theoretical support in Roland Barthes's portrait of Japan as an "empire of signs" emptied of transcendent reference (Barthes 1970), in Jean Baudrillard's account of the simulacrum (1981), and in Azuma Hiroki's description of otaku culture as the recombination of detachable elements drawn from a database (2001). On this view the cross-shaped explosions that mark the deaths of Angels are graphic events, not signs of sacrifice. Against it stands an esoteric reading, pursued with great ingenuity by fan exegesis, that treats the imagery as the key to a hidden and coherent cosmology whose doctrines the text encrypts.

Both readings assume that a borrowed sign either keeps its meaning whole or loses it entirely. The history of religions offers a third possibility, and Japanese religious history offers it in an especially developed form. The medieval doctrine of *honji suijaku* ("original ground, manifest trace") explained the native kami as local traces of Buddhist originals, and thereby allowed two sacred systems to occupy the same sites without either absorbing the other. The practice of the *yorishiro* — an object, tree, or person into which a kami descends — supplies a native theory of how a foreign power can inhabit a vessel without becoming identical with it. Maruyama's *basso ostinato*, introduced above, describes the result at the level of intellectual history: imported doctrines are received, but bent by a persistent low register.

This thesis calls the resulting mode of transmission *osmotic*. When a sign crosses a cultural membrane, some of its components pass and others do not. What passes is morphology: shape, function, position within a system of relations. What is retained is doctrine: the creedal content that gave the sign its authority at its source. The cross in *Evangelion* is not the cross of redemption, but it remains a figure of crossing — of the intersection of two lines, two orders, two bodies — and it recurs at every point where one order of being breaches another. The corpus itself uses the vocabulary of the *yorishiro*: in EoE, SEELE designates Unit-01 and its pilot as the vessel into which Instrumentality will descend. A Christian eschatology descends into a Shinto receptacle, and neither is converted into the other.

2.2 Two trees

Genesis plants two trees in the garden: the tree of life and the tree of the knowledge of good and evil (Gen 2:9). Humanity eats of the second and is expelled "lest he put forth his hand, and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live for ever" (Gen 3:22). The corpus distributes the two trees across two races. The Angels, children of Adam, possess the Fruit of Life, figured as the S^2 engine, an inexhaustible power source that makes them self-sufficient; the Lilin, children of Lilith, possess the Fruit of Knowledge — science, culture, the capacity to make instruments — and are mortal. Each lacks what the other has, and the being that possessed both would be a god. When Unit-01 devours the S^2 engine of Zeruel in Episode 19, it becomes such a being in embryo, and the image by which the corpus presents the union of life and knowledge is a monster eating.

Two philosophical glosses on the Fall frame the corpus's position. Kant's "Conjectural Beginning of Human History" (1786) reads the expulsion as the passage of reason out of the guardianship of instinct into freedom: a fall for the individual, progress for the species. The Gnostic tradition, in texts such as the *Hypostasis of the Archons*, reads the serpent as a revealer and the knowledge it offers as the beginning of salvation from an ignorant creator. The corpus sides with neither and borrows the shape of both. Knowledge is not a sin to be expiated, as SEELE believes, nor the key to escape from the world, as the Gnostic believes, but the condition of culture — of the song that Kaworu, in Episode 24, calls the height of what the Lilin have made.

The emblem of NERV condenses the argument: half of a fig leaf, bearing the motto "God's in his heaven, all's right with the world." The fig leaf is the first artifact in the biblical narrative. The first act of the knowing couple is to sew themselves coverings (Gen 3:7); knowledge produces shame, and shame produces the first artificial membrane — a boundary that answers the discovery of being seen, as Sartre (1943) would later describe it. NERV's emblem shows the membrane half made. The motto comes from Robert Browning's *Pippa Passes* (1841), in which a silk-winder from Asolo spends her one holiday walking through the town singing, and her songs, overheard at decisive moments, unknowingly alter the fates of guilty adults — among them a pair of adulterous murderers. An innocent child whose passage redirects the lives of compromised adults is an exact description of the Children. The motto's grammar is theological as well: all is right because God is *in his heaven* — on his side of the firmament. SEELE's project is to storm that heaven.

2.3 Lilith and the axiom of refusal

The name Lilith appears once in the Hebrew Bible, among the creatures of a desolated land (Isa 34:14), and descends from Mesopotamian demonology. Her decisive literary form comes in the medieval *Alphabet of Ben Sira*. There she is created from the earth like Adam, refuses to lie beneath him on the ground that both were made from the same earth and are therefore equal, and, when he tries to compel her, pronounces the ineffable Name and flies away. God sends three angels — Senoy, Sansenoy, and Semangelof — who overtake her in the waters where the Egyptians would later drown, that is, in the Red Sea; she refuses to return. Later tradition, including the *Zohar*, makes her the consort of Samael and a threat to newborns, against whom amulets bearing the three angels' names were hung.

Evangelion makes humanity the children of Lilith — the Lilin — and hangs her, crucified and masked with SEELE's seven-eyed visor, at the bottom of Terminal Dogma. The sea to which Ben Sira's Lilith flees is red; the sea to which her children return in EoE is red. And EoE replays the structure of Ben Sira with startling fidelity. Gendo, who has grafted the embryonic Adam into his right hand, attempts to initiate his own version of Instrumentality by pushing that hand into the body of Rei — a girl he made from Lilith and his wife's genetic material and raised as his instrument — so as to fuse with her and reach his wife through her. It is an adult man taking possession of a girl's body without her consent. Rei refuses: she is not his doll; she is not him. She takes the hand bearing Adam into herself and returns to Lilith, and the exchange that marks the reunion is the ordinary Japanese greeting of homecoming, *tadaima* answered by *okaerinasai*. Ben Sira's Lilith refuses sexual subordination to Adam; Rei refuses the use of her body by the man who literally holds Adam. Each asserts her difference, and each departs to the waters.

From this replay the thesis draws its second original claim, the *Lilithic axiom*: whatever can love can refuse. Humanity in *Evangelion* descends from a woman whose founding act was refusal, and every genuine relation in the corpus passes through one — Rei's refusal of Gendo, Shinji's refusal of Instrumentality, Kaworu's refusal of the role SEELE assigned him, and Asuka's closing *kimochi warui*, treated in Chapter Three. The Evangelions confirm the axiom in their own register. Their name encodes Eve as well as the Gospel, and in Episode 19 Ritsuko discloses that their armor is not armor but restraint (*kōsokugu*), holding back a power the pilots do not control. When Unit-01 goes berserk, the restraint fails and the mother within says no. Kotani's reading of the Evangelions as monstrous maternal bodies (1997) is here extended: the monstrous mother is the one who can refuse.

2.4 Gnosis, SEELE, and the Simonian template

Hans Jonas's reconstruction of Gnosticism (1934; 1958), confirmed and complicated by the Nag Hammadi codices discovered in 1945, describes a family of myths in which a transcendent God stands above an inferior creator and his archons, a divine spark is imprisoned in matter, and salvation consists in knowledge that frees the spark to return to the fullness (*pleroma*). The return is lysis on a cosmic scale: the dissolution of every particular in the undivided. SEELE belongs to this family. Its members appear as numbered black monoliths labeled SOUND ONLY, voices without bodies, and its scenario is drawn from a set of "Dead Sea Scrolls" unknown to scholarship — a pointed choice, since the scrolls actually recovered near Qumran from 1947 include the *War Scroll*, which prescribes the order of battle for an eschatological war between the Sons of Light and the Sons of Darkness. The Angels arrive, by and large, in the order the scrolls predict. SEELE's chairman, Keel, is revealed in EoE to inhabit a largely mechanical body: the old men who would free humanity from its bodies have already begun to leave their own.

The most exact Gnostic template for the corpus, however, has not been identified in the critical literature. Irenaeus (*Against Heresies* I.23.2–3) reports that Simon Magus, whom the heresiologists made the father of all heresies, traveled with a woman named Helen whom he had found in a brothel in Tyre. He taught that she was his First Thought (*Ennoia*), the mother

of all, who had generated the angels and powers who made the world; that the powers, out of envy, had detained her in bodies, so that she passed from body to body through the ages; and that he had come to free her and to offer salvation through knowledge of himself.

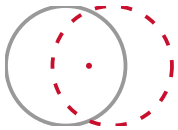
The correspondence with Gendo and Yui is structural and extensive. Yui is Gendo's Ennoia, the intelligence — she is the scientist — who originated the instruments that make the world of the series; she is detained in a body made by the powers, Unit-01, built within the program of SEELE and its predecessor Gehirn; and she passes, in effect, from body to body, since the successive Reis, made from her genetic material, are her serial reincarnations. Gendo founds an organization whose public purpose conceals a private gnosis and whose true end is to free her. The template also clarifies what the corpus changes. Yui was not captured: she chose her captivity, entering Unit-01 deliberately in order to remain. Where Sophia falls through desire, Yui descends by decision; her imprisonment is a kenosis, not a fall. And the Gnostic redeemer is refused by the Ennoia he would redeem: Rei's "I am not your doll" is Helen's answer to Simon. The Simonian drama is replayed in order to be reversed.

Three further borrowings confirm the osmotic model. The last Angel, Kaworu, bears the name Tabris, which Gustav Davidson's *Dictionary of Angels* (1967), following Éliphas Lévi's *Nuctemeron*, glosses as the genius of free will; the Japanese title of his episode, *Saigo no shisha*, writes the syllable *shi* in katakana (シ), so that it can be read both as 使者, "messenger," and 死者, "the dead" — a sign that lets two meanings pass. The Lance of Longinus takes its name from the soldier who pierced the side of Christ, from which, in the Johannine account, "forthwith came there out blood and water" (John 19:34): the substance of LCL is the fluid released by that wound. And the seven eyes of SEELE's emblem recall the Lamb "having seven horns and seven eyes, which are the seven Spirits of God sent forth into all the earth" (Rev 5:6), and the eyes of the Lord that "run to and fro through the whole earth" (Zech 4:10): a gaze without a boundary, the visual form of the totality SEELE seeks.

2.5 Osmotic semiotics

Barthes's most famous image of Japan is Tokyo's empty center: the Imperial Palace, a forbidden and invisible space around which the city turns (Barthes 1970). Tokyo-3 also has a hollow center, but it is not empty. The Geofront contains a buried sphere, and at the bottom of its descending shafts hangs a mother. Barthes's empty signifier becomes, in *Evangelion*, a chamber — a womb, a *Guf*. The emptiness of the imported sign is not a void but a receptacle, and what it receives is transformed.

The corpus relates to its sources as the osmotic self relates to others. It takes them in without converting to them; it transforms them without denying their foreignness. The Hebrew letters, German names, Latin script, and Greek title remain visibly foreign in the Japanese text, and the membrane that marks their difference is precisely what lets them work. The contrast with Aum Shinrikyō, which also assembled Christian apocalyptic, Buddhist practice, and science fiction, is instructive. Aum dissolved its sources into a single totalizing doctrine and acted upon it; its syncretism was lytic. *Evangelion*'s syncretism is osmotic, and this is the thesis's fourth original claim: the text's form of borrowing reproduces its theme. A work that argues for semipermeable selves is itself a semipermeable text.



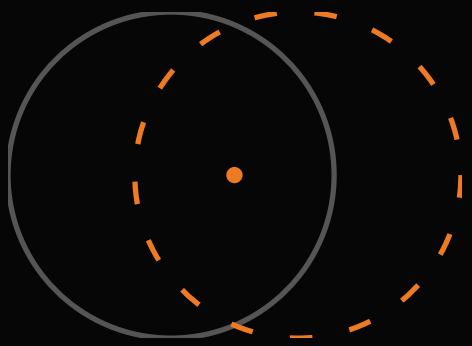
CHAPTER THREE

03

第三章

The Thalassal Complex

Psychoanalytic Genealogies of the Return



The psychoanalytic stratum of *Evangelion* is a genealogy of the wish to return — to the womb, to the sea, to the undifferentiated — and its decisive innovation is to relocate the force that interrupts that return from the Father's prohibition to the Other's refusal. The episode titles advertise the stratum; this chapter excavates it, from Freud's oceanic feeling through Ferenczi, Rank, Klein, Winnicott, Lacan, Kristeva, and Laing, to the Japanese psychology of *amae* and the "maternal society."

3.1 The oceanic and the terminable

Civilization and Its Discontents (Freud 1930) opens with a letter from Romain Rolland, who proposed that the true source of religious feeling is an "oceanic" sensation of limitless union with the world. Freud, who confessed he could not find the feeling in himself, explained it as a survival of the infantile ego-feeling that precedes the ego's separation from the external world, when the infant does not yet distinguish its own body from the breast. The oceanic is thus a memory of the time before the membrane. Ten years earlier, *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) had proposed a drive whose aim is to restore an earlier state of things, ultimately the inorganic: a death drive tending toward the reduction of tension to zero, which Freud aligned with the Nirvana principle named by Barbara Low. Edoardo Weiss later gave the destructive energy of this drive the name *destrudo*, and EoE's dialogue borrows the term.

Freud's late essay "Analysis Terminable and Interminable" (1937) raises the question the television finale answers. *Analysis* is, etymologically, a loosening up (ἀνά + λύσις), and Freud asks whether the loosening can ever be concluded. Episodes 25 and 26 stage Instrumentality not as a flood but as an analysis: a sequence of interrogations — what do you want, why do you pilot, what are you afraid of — conducted in darkened rooms under a spotlight, in which the characters' defenses are loosened and examined. This is lysis in the analytic sense: the dissolution not of bodies but of knots. And the analysis terminates. The final episode closes on applause and congratulations, the patient discharged into a world he has chosen. EoE performs lysis in the physiological sense instead, and the difference between the two finales is the difference between loosening a knot and dissolving a cell.

3.2 Ferenczi: *Thalassa* and introjection

Sándor Ferenczi's *Versuch einer Genitaltheorie* (1924; English *Thalassa*, 1938) is the most daring text in the psychoanalytic canon and the one closest to *Evangelion*'s imagination. Ferenczi proposed that the deepest aim of the drives expresses a "thalassal regressive trend": a longing to return to the maternal womb, which is itself an ontogenetic substitute for the sea that life abandoned when the primeval oceans receded. Amniotic fluid is an internalized ocean; birth repeats the catastrophe of emergence onto land; and the organism strives toward the water it lost. The entry plug of an Evangelion, flooded with LCL that its pilot must breathe, literalizes Ferenczi's speculation: the pilot lives in the womb and in the sea at once, breathing liquid inside the mother's body. Instrumentality completes the thalassal trend at the scale of the species.

Ferenczi is present in the corpus by name as well as by structure. His paper "Introjection and Transference" (1909) introduced *introjection*, the process by which the ego extends itself to take the objects of the external world into its own sphere. Episode 19 is subtitled "Introjection," and its climax is Unit-01's devouring of the Angel Zeruel: introjection performed as eating. Episode 20 is subtitled "Oral Stage," and invokes Karl Abraham's division of orality (1924) into an early, sucking, pre-ambivalent phase and a later, biting, cannibalistic one. Both phases appear. Unit-01's feast is oral-sadistic; Shinji's dissolution into the LCL of his cockpit in the following episode is pre-ambivalent — a return to a state in which there is no object because there is no subject. EoE multiplies the cannibalism, as the mass-produced Evangelions tear open and devour Unit-02 with Asuka inside it.

The oral register exposes the logic of lysis. To eat is to dissolve another's boundary into one's own; digestion is enzymatic lysis. Every fantasy of incorporation is a fantasy of ending the other's membrane. Osmosis admits no such figure. Its paradigm is not eating but breathing: not incorporation but exchange.

3.3 Rank: birth and farewell

Otto Rank's *The Trauma of Birth* (1924) made separation from the mother the prototype of all anxiety and conceived therapy as a second birth. *Evangelion* stages three births in Rank's sense. In Episode 16, Shinji is swallowed by Leliel, an Angel whose body is a shadow opening onto what the characters call a Dirac sea of imaginary space; after a long interior dialogue with a divided image of himself, Unit-01 tears its way out of the Angel from within, emerging in a spray of blood with a cry. In Episode 20, having reached a synchronization ratio of 400 percent, Shinji dissolves into the LCL of his entry plug; the technicians' attempt to "salvage" him fails, and his reconstitution is figured as a release by the mother who holds him, after which he spills from the plug onto the floor like a newborn. And the television series ends with a card that reads as a Rankian formula: to my father, thank you; to my mother, farewell; and to all the Children, congratulations. The child thanks the father, parts from the mother, and receives the congratulations (*omedetō*) with which Japanese greets a birth.

3.4 Klein: splitting, ambivalence, reparation

Melanie Klein described two positions in early psychic life (Klein 1935; 1946). In the paranoid-schizoid position, the infant splits its object into a gratifying good breast and a persecuting bad one, projecting its own aggression into the latter. In the depressive position, it comes to recognize that the good and the bad breast belong to one person, whom it both loves and has attacked; ambivalence becomes tolerable, guilt appears, and with it the wish to make reparation. Episode 16 is subtitled "Splitting of the Breast," Episode 18 "Ambivalence," and the episodes stage the passage between positions. In Episode 18, Shinji is ordered to destroy Unit-03, which has been infected by the Angel Bardiel and which, he learns too late, is piloted by his friend Toji. He refuses to split friend from enemy. Gendo overrides him by activating the Dummy Plug — a pilot-substitute derived from Rei — and the machine performs the splitting

Shinji would not, crushing the entry plug in its hand with Toji inside; he survives, maimed. The first great scene of rage between son and father follows.

Asuka embodies Klein's manic defense: control, triumph, and contempt deployed against dependence. Her mother, Kyoko, having lost part of herself in a contact experiment with Unit-02, came to treat a doll as her daughter and hanged herself; Asuka's imperative to be seen and to excel is the demand of a child whom her mother did not see. The defense collapses in Episode 22, when Arael forces its way into her mind. Its resolution comes in EoE, when Asuka, submerged in Unit-02 at the bottom of a lake, recognizes that her mother has been present within the machine all along. The depressive position is the psychoanalytic name for the osmotic capacity: to hold another as whole and separate, good and bad, loved and lost, and to answer loss with reparation rather than fusion.

3.5 Winnicott: the transitional object and the capacity to be alone

Donald Winnicott's transitional object (1953) — the blanket or toy that belongs neither wholly to the infant's inner world nor to external reality — occupies an intermediate area in which the self learns to relate to what it does not control. Shinji's transitional object is his SDAT player, whose earphones seal him within a membrane of sound and whose display cycles between tracks 25 and 26 — the numbers of the series' final episodes. The Rebuild tetralogy reveals that the player was originally Gendo's: the son's membrane is inherited from the father, whose own confession in *3.0+1.0* describes a life spent behind walls of music and knowledge.

Winnicott's "The Capacity to Be Alone" (1958) adds a paradox the corpus understands. The capacity to be alone rests on the experience of having been alone in the presence of someone, originally the mother: solitude is a relational achievement. Its failure produces either isolation or merger. Winnicott's distinction between a true and a false self (1960) completes the picture. The false self is built on compliance with the demands of the environment. Shinji's mantra, *nigecha dame da*, is a false-self formation, the internalized command of a father who summoned his son only to use him; his true self speaks only at the end of the television series, in the sentence treated in Chapter Four: it is all right for me to be here.

3.6 Lacan: the mirror, the missing Name, and the Other's No

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its own image as an alienating identification: the unity it sees is not the unity it has. Rei is the mirror of *Evangelion*. She bears Yui's face; Gendo looks at her and sees his wife; Shinji looks at her and sees his mother; in EoE her apparitions appear to each dissolving person in the shape of what he or she desires. For Lacan the child is separated from the mother by the paternal function, the Name-of-the-Father (*Nom-du-Père*), punning on the Father's prohibition (*Non-du-Père*). Gendo exercises the No without the Name. He forbids, abandons, and commands, but he gives his son no law, because he wants the mother for himself: his entire project is to recover Yui. The paternal function is corrupted at its source, and the father becomes the son's rival for the mother rather than the agent of their separation.

The corpus's answer, this chapter argues, is to relocate the separating function. If the Father will not separate the child from the mother, the Other must: the refusal of another subject replaces the prohibition of the law. Rei's refusal of Gendo, Asuka's refusal of Shinji, and the refusal of the Rei-Lilith figure to hold Shinji in the sea against his will are separations effected not by a patriarchal No but by persons who will not be absorbed. Saitō Tamaki's analysis of the "beautiful fighting girl" as a phallic figure for otaku desire (2000) is overturned at this point: when Asuka refuses, in EoE's kitchen sequence, to become the object of Shinji's need, the phallic girl of the fantasy becomes the subject of a refusal — and Shinji answers the refusal by strangling her, the first of the film's two stranglings. Refusal re-establishes the boundary; it does not by itself stop the violence aimed at it.

3.7 Kristeva: the *chora* and abjection

Julia Kristeva borrowed from Plato's *Timaeus* (48e–52d) the *chora*, the receptacle and "nurse of becoming" that receives all forms and possesses none, to name a pre-symbolic, rhythmic, maternal space (Kristeva 1974). LCL is the *chora* rendered as substance: a receptacle that receives every human form and holds none. Kristeva's later theory of abjection (1980), building on Mary Douglas's account of pollution, describes the abject as what must be expelled for a subject to form — the corpse, bodily waste, the skin on the surface of milk — neither subject nor object, but the boundary under threat. The first abjection is of the maternal body, and nausea is its affect.

EoE ends with that affect. On the shore of the red sea, after Shinji has returned and has tried to strangle Asuka, after her hand has risen to touch his face and he has broken down, Asuka speaks the last words of the film: *kimochi warui* — "I feel sick," "this is disgusting." The line is routinely read as a verdict on Shinji, and it is one; the question is what kind. The film opens with Shinji alone at Asuka's hospital bedside while she lies comatose: he masturbates over her body, then calls himself the lowest of the low. Both are fourteen. It is a sexual violation of someone who can neither know of it nor refuse it — the film's first act of lysis in its plainest moral form, one person using another's body across a boundary she has no power to defend. Miyamura Yūko, who voices Asuka, has recounted in a widely reported account that Anno, dissatisfied with her readings of the final line, asked her to imagine waking to find that a stranger had done exactly this to her in her sleep, and to say what she would say; her answer became the line. *Kimochi warui* therefore answers the opening scene. It is the founding affect of re-individuation precisely because it is the first refusal of a person whose capacity to refuse had been suspended — by coma, by Shinji's act, by the mass-produced Evangelions that tore Unit-02 apart around her — and it restores her boundary first against the one who breached it. The film begins with the violation of someone who cannot refuse and ends with her refusal; the restored membrane is, before anything else, a judgment. Freud's account of the uncanny (1919) as the return of the once-familiar, the *heimlich* become *unheimlich*, supplies the final gloss. Instrumentality presents itself as homecoming — *tadaima*, *okaerinasai* — and the home to which it returns is the uncanny par excellence.

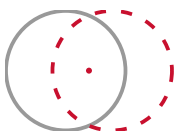
3.8 Laing: ontological insecurity and the knots of love

R. D. Laing's *The Divided Self* (1960) describes the ontologically insecure person, who lacks a firm sense of the boundary between self and world, and three forms of anxiety to which such a person is exposed. In *engulfment*, relatedness itself threatens to swallow the self, which therefore defends itself by isolation; in *implosion*, the world is felt as a vacuum ready to rush in and obliterate identity; in *petrification*, the other's gaze threatens to turn the self into a thing. The late Angels embody these anxieties with diagnostic precision. Leliel, whose shadow opens onto an imaginary space that swallows Shinji, is implosion. Arael, which bathes Asuka in a beam of light that forces its way into her mind, drags up her mother's suicide, and leaves her catatonic — an assault she herself describes as defilement — is petrification. Armisael, which penetrates Unit-00 and attempts to fuse with Rei — who feels its loneliness as her own, discovers that she is weeping, and destroys herself to save Shinji — is engulfment. Laing's *Knots* (1970) diagrams the double binds of love, and the English title of Episode 25, "Do you love me?", is the title of his book of 1976.

The Japanese psychoanalytic tradition supplies the cultural register of the same problem. Doi Takeo's *The Anatomy of Dependence* (1971) identified *amae*, the wish to presume upon another's indulgence and to be passively loved, as a central Japanese affect; Instrumentality is *amae* made absolute, a world in which no one can refuse anyone. Kawai Hayao's *The Pathology of Japan as a Maternal Society* (1976) contrasted a maternal principle that contains and equalizes with a paternal principle that cuts and discriminates, and described the difficulty of separating an ego from the enveloping mother. Erich Neumann's *The Origins and History of Consciousness* (1949) described the undifferentiated beginning as the uroboros, the regressive wish as "uroboric incest," and the birth of consciousness as the hero's slaying of the Great Mother. *Evangelion* rejects both Kawai's dissolution and Neumann's matricide. Its Children separate from their mothers by farewell, not murder. And in EoE the image of Unit-01 closing its jaws on Gendo reverses the myth of Kronos: it is not the father who devours his children but the mother who devours the father's wish for fusion.

3.9 Conclusion

The psychoanalytic stratum yields the thesis's formal claim about separation: in a world where the Father's law has failed, separation must pass through the refusal of another person, and the affect that marks the restored boundary is not joy but aversion. The corpus does not glorify that aversion. It treats it as the first skin of a self that can, later, be touched.



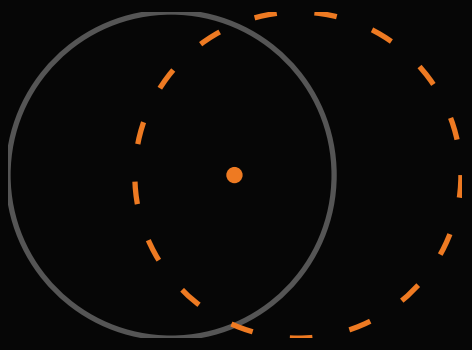
CHAPTER FOUR

04

第四章

The Wall of the Heart

Existence, Recognition, and Japanese Philosophies of Betweenness



The existential stratum of *Evangelion* poses the porcupine's question — how close may selves come without wounding one another? — and answers it neither with distance nor with fusion but with a transformation of the boundary itself, a solution the corpus finds most fully articulated not in European existentialism but in the Japanese and Buddhist philosophies of betweenness. The chapter proceeds from Schopenhauer and Nietzsche through Kierkegaard, Heidegger, Sartre, Hegel, and Levinas to Watsuji, Nishida, Nishitani, and Huayan.

4.1 The porcupines and their three solutions

The second volume of Schopenhauer's *Parerga and Paralipomena* (1851, §396) contains the parable the series made famous. A company of porcupines crowd together on a cold winter's day to keep warm, are driven apart by their quills, and are driven together again by the cold, until they find a moderate distance at which they can best endure one another. The need for society, Schopenhauer explains, drives human beings together, and their many repellent qualities drive them apart; the moderate distance they finally discover is politeness and good manners. He adds that a person with much inner warmth of his own prefers to stay away from society altogether. Freud cited the parable in *Group Psychology and the Analysis of the Ego* (1921). Ritsuko glosses it early in the series, and Episode 4 takes its English title from it. The Japanese term, *yamaarashi no jirenma*, preserves Schopenhauer's porcupine; the English "hedgehog" is a softening.

The parable admits three solutions, and the corpus stages each. The *metric* solution is Schopenhauer's own: adjust the distance until the pain is tolerable. It is the solution of politeness, and of the first half of the series, in which Shinji, running away and returning, learns the approximate distance at which others can be borne; its cost is chill. The *abolitionist* solution is SEELE's: remove the quills. Instrumentality abolishes the pain of proximity by abolishing the bodies that feel it; it is the solution of EoE's red sea. The *topological* solution is the corpus's own, and it changes the nature of the surface rather than the distance between surfaces. The quills become pores; the wall becomes a membrane; relation ceases to be a function of distance and becomes a function of permeability. This is the Hedgehog Theorem of Chapter Eight.

The corpus's institutions carry the imprint of Schopenhauer's metaphysics as well as his parable. SEELE is German for soul; Gehirn, NERV's predecessor, for brain; NERV for nerve; and the insurgent organization of the Rebuild films, WILLE, for will — the Schopenhauerian name for the single striving that appears, under the *principium individuationis* of space and time, as a multitude of separate beings. For Schopenhauer, individuation is appearance, the veil of Maya, and compassion is the moral recognition that the other is at bottom oneself. Instrumentality is Schopenhauer's ethics made physics: it does not see through the veil but tears it. That the organization which finally resists it is named for the Will — the principle that, in Schopenhauer, individuates itself — reads, on this account, less as accident than as program.

4.2 Dionysus and the Ode to Joy

Nietzsche's *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) took over Schopenhauer's *principium individuationis* as the domain of Apollo, god of form, measure, and dream, and set against it Dionysus, under whose intoxication the boundaries between persons collapse and the individual is restored to "primordial unity" (*das Ur-Eine*). In the first section of the book Nietzsche invokes Beethoven's setting of Schiller's "Ode to Joy" as the image of that collapse: the millions prostrate in the dust, every barrier between human beings broken. *Evangelion* sets exactly that music at exactly that point. In Episode 24, the choral finale of the Ninth Symphony accompanies Kaworu's descent through Terminal Dogma toward the giant he believes to be Adam, and the battle between Units 01 and 02 that follows him down: Schiller's "Seid umschlungen, Millionen!" — be embraced, you millions — sounds as the Angel of free will seeks the origin. Earlier Kaworu, humming the melody, had called song the height of the culture the Lilin produced. The Dionysian is admired and then refused: the Angel, arriving, finds not Adam but Lilith, and chooses death over the reunion he came to perform.

EoE extends the figure into kitsch. As humanity dissolves, the soundtrack plays "Komm, süsser Tod," an English-language pop song that takes its title from a sacred song in the Schemelli hymnal (BWV 478), and whose buoyant surface is set against the dissolution of the species. Georges Bataille's *L'Érotisme* (1957) supplies the theory of the moment: human beings are discontinuous, separated by an abyss, and nostalgic for a lost continuity that eroticism, sacrifice, and death briefly restore. EoE stages Bataillean continuity at planetary scale and finds it not ecstatic but nightmarish — a giant white body, an orange sea, a pop song.

4.3 The sickness unto death

The Japanese title of Episode 16, *Shi ni itaru yamai, soshite* — "The Sickness unto Death, and…" — names Kierkegaard's treatise (1849), published under the pseudonym Anti-Climacus, whose central claim is that the self is a relation that relates itself to itself, and that despair is a misrelation in that relation. Kierkegaard distinguishes the despair that is unaware of having a self; the despair of weakness, which does not will to be itself; the despair of defiance, which wills despairingly to be itself by its own power; and, as defiance intensified into spite against existence, the demonic. The principal characters instantiate the typology. Rei, in the early episodes, embodies the despair unaware of having a self: she says she has nothing else. Shinji embodies the despair of weakness: he does not will to be himself, and wishes to be anyone, or no one. Asuka embodies defiance: she wills to be herself entirely by her own power, and her collapse is the collapse of that will. Gendo is demonic: his despair has become a project against existence itself, the undoing of the world to recover what it took from him.

Kierkegaard's cure is faith: the self rests transparently in the power that established it. The corpus secularizes the formula without flattening it. The self rests not in God but in its relation to others, and the transparency it attains is not fusion but the capacity to be seen without dissolving. Kierkegaard's formal insight — that the self is not a substance but a relation relating itself to itself — is already osmotic: a self is constituted at its boundary.

4.4 Being-there and the drawn line

Heidegger's *Being and Time* (1927) describes human existence as *Dasein*, being-there: thrown into a world it did not choose, absorbed in the anonymous "they" (*das Man*), constituted by being-with others (*Mitsein*), and individualized only in anticipating its own death. The last sentence Shinji speaks in the television series — *boku wa koko ni ite mo ii n da*, "it is all right for me to be here" — translates *Dasein* into affect: an affirmation of the *there* of existence, of having a place (*ibasho*) in the world. The route to that sentence passes through the most radical image in the series. In Episode 26, Shinji floats in a white void without direction; he is told that this is freedom, a world without constraint; and a hand draws a single pencil line across the empty space. The line is a ground. Shinji can now stand, walk, fall. The limit does not restrict his freedom but constitutes it — Spinoza's *determinatio est negatio* (Letter 50) rendered in graphite, and a restatement of Genesis 1, in which a world begins when a line is drawn through the deep.

Camus (1942) answered the absurd with revolt and imagined Sisyphus happy. Kaworu answers it with death, which he calls the only absolute freedom. The corpus gives a third answer through Yui, who tells her son in EoE, in substance, that anywhere can become paradise if one resolves to live. This is not Camusian revolt but the will to live that Schopenhauer condemned and that WILLE, in Rebuild, embodies: life affirmed not as the overcoming of limits but as their acceptance.

4.5 The Look, recognition, and the face

For Sartre (1943) the Other appears first in the Look, which objectifies me and reveals me to myself in shame; the Other is the one who steals my world. *No Exit* (1944) dramatized the result: three people in a room, each condemned to the others' judgment. The interrogations of Episodes 25 and 26, conducted under a spotlight in darkened chambers, are a *Huis clos* of the Children. Asuka's demand, in her memories and in the finale — look at me — is the demand of a subject who can exist only as seen, because the one who should have looked at her looked at a doll.

Hegel's dialectic of recognition (1807), and Kojève's reading of it (1947), make desire the desire for another's desire and history the struggle for recognition. Kaworu interrupts that struggle in Episode 24 with a gratuitous recognition: he tells Shinji that he is worthy of goodwill (*kōi ni atai suru*), and then, in the bath, that this means he loves him (*suki tte koto sa*; *suki* covers both "like" and "love"). The scene is widely read as a romantic declaration from one boy to another, and the 2019 English subtitles' "like" drew criticism for muting it. The love is given without struggle and without demand; it asks nothing back, not even that Shinji stay. It is the corpus's first image of a love that regards rather than fuses.

Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) supplies the ethical frame of the ending. For Levinas, separation is not a fall but the condition of ethics: only a separated being, at home with itself, can welcome the Other, and the Other appears in the face, whose first expression is the command not to kill. Totality — war, the system, the absorption of the Other into the Same — is the denial of that command. On the beach of EoE, Shinji closes his hands around Asuka's

throat for the second time in the film: the lytic temptation in its purest form, the attempt to confirm the Other's existence by the possibility of annihilating it, or to end her otherness by ending her. Asuka does not resist. Her hand rises and touches his face, and he stops. The gesture is neither submission nor struggle; it is the face speaking. Then she says *kimochi warui*, and separation is restored. The ending is Levinasian in structure: the Other's vulnerability halts the murder, and her refusal establishes the distance within which ethics becomes possible.

4.6 *Ningen*: Watsuji and the species that is not a person

Watsuji Tetsurō's *Ethics as the Study of Ningen* (1934) and his three-volume *Ethics* (1937–49) begin from a word. The Japanese *ningen*, "human being," is written with the characters for "person" (人) and "between" (間). A human being, Watsuji argued, is not an isolated individual but a betweenness (*aidagara*): individual and social at once, existing in relations that precede and constitute it. Ethics is the movement of a double negation. The individual negates the community in order to become an individual; the individual then negates its own individuality to return to the community; and the ground of the whole movement is emptiness (*kū*). Watsuji's system has a notorious shadow. In its wartime formulations it exalted the state as the highest form of ethical totality and risked dissolving the first negation into the second. SEELE is Watsuji's shadow carried to completion: the second negation without the first, totality without individuals.

The Japanese title of the project makes the critique exact. Instrumentality is *jinrui hokan keikaku*, the project for the completion of *jinrui* — 人類, humankind as a biological kind, a class of specimens. It is not a project for *ningen*. SEELE addresses humanity as a species and proposes to perfect it by abolishing the "between" that makes each member a person. The corpus answers in its episode titles. Episode 22 is titled *Semete, ningen rashiku* — "At least, like a human being" — and Episode 20 *Kokoro no katachi, hito no katachi* — "The shape of the heart, the shape of the person." Against *jinrui*, the corpus insists on *ningen* and *hito*: on the person as a form sustained between others. *3.0+1.0* gives the insistence its most concrete image. In Village 3, the clone of Rei learns to be a person by learning greetings — good morning, good night, thank you, goodbye — the elementary forms of *aidagara*.

4.7 *Basho*, emptiness, and the net of Indra

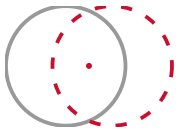
Nishida Kitarō's logic of place (*basho*, 1926) located beings within a "place of nothingness" that is not a void but the field in which beings are determined, and his late formula of "absolutely contradictory self-identity" (1939) described the identity of the one and the many as a unity that preserves their contradiction. The A.T. Field, at once wall and light (*kabe* and *hikari*), is such an identity. The same field that separates illuminates: one can see only what is not oneself, and light requires a distance to cross.

Nishitani Keiji's *What Is Religion?* (1961) distinguished nihility (*kyomu*), the abyss of meaninglessness that opens beneath the self when its foundations collapse, from emptiness

(*śūnyatā*, *kū*), a field on which each thing is most fully itself precisely because it is present in the home-ground of every other. Nishitani borrowed the Christian term *circuminsession* for this mutual indwelling. The red sea of LCL is nihility masquerading as emptiness. It resembles *śūnyatā*: there are no boundaries, and everything is in everything. But in it no thing is itself. True emptiness preserves the suchness of each being; nihility erases it. The ordinary, distinct, and interdependent world into which *3.0+1.0* releases its characters is closer to *śūnyatā* than the sea ever was.

The Huayan school of Chinese Buddhism gave the principle its most famous image: the net of the god Indra, at each knot of which hangs a jewel that reflects every other jewel and every reflection, infinitely. Fazang is said to have demonstrated the doctrine to Empress Wu with a room of mirrors surrounding a statue of the Buddha. The net figures the unobstructed interpenetration of phenomenon with phenomenon (Japanese *jijimuge*): total mutual presence without fusion. Every jewel remains a jewel; every knot is a membrane that reflects and transmits. In the red sea there are no jewels, only fluid. The corpus contains its own miniature of the net. In Episode 9, the Angel Israfel divides into two bodies that must be destroyed at the same instant, and Shinji and Asuka defeat it by training, while living together, to move in perfect unison — synchronization without fusion, two bodies in one rhythm.

Three traditions converge on a single grammar. The Council of Chalcedon (451) defined the union of two natures in one person as without confusion, without change, without division, without separation. Bakhtin (1929; 1963) described the Dostoevskian novel as a polyphony of "unmerged" voices, a term that carries, through Russian theological usage, the Chalcedonian vocabulary of the unconfused. Huayan describes interpenetration without obstruction. Each names a union that does not dissolve its members. Osmosis is that grammar stated in physical terms.



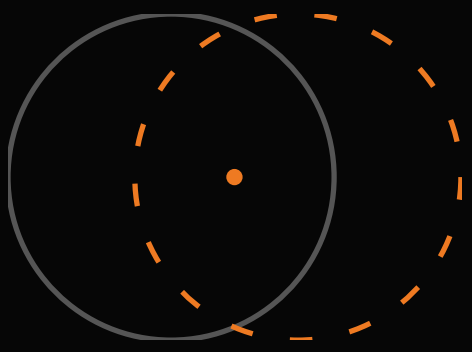
CHAPTER FIVE

05

第五章

The Instrumentality of Mankind

Eschatology, Technocracy, and the Japanese 1990s



Human Instrumentality is a technocratic eschatology — salvation administered by an institution — and the corpus diagnoses it as the terminal form of a society that has lost its middle, the social space between the self and the world. This chapter traces the project's name to its source, sets it against the eschatologies of union from which it descends, anatomizes the institutions that pursue it, and reads it against the Japanese 1990s: Aum, the "endless everyday," the debates over *otaku*, *hikikomori*, and *sekai-kei*, and the figure of the child soldier.

5.1 Cordwainer Smith and the logic of the supplement

The English name of the project comes from the science fiction of Cordwainer Smith, the pseudonym of Paul Linebarger (1913–1966), a scholar of East Asian politics, godson of Sun Yat-sen, and author of *Psychological Warfare* (1948). Smith's future history is governed by the Instrumentality of Mankind, an ancient and paternalistic technocracy of immortal Lords. His first published story, "Scanners Live in Vain" (1950), imagines the Scanners, spacefarers surgically severed from their senses so that they can survive the "Great Pain of Space"; they may briefly "cranch," reconnecting to feeling at the risk of their lives, and are rendered obsolete when it is discovered that surrounding a ship with living matter shields ordinary humans from the Pain. The Scanner is the inverse of the Eva pilot. The Scanner feels nothing so that he can travel; the pilot, synchronized with his machine, feels its every wound.

The later stories of the cycle turn on what Smith called the Rediscovery of Man: the Lords of the Instrumentality, having made humanity safe, healthy, and perfectly content, find that it has ceased to be human, and deliberately reintroduce uncertainty, danger, illness, old languages, and old cultures. The source of the project's name thus already contains the refusal of the project. Shinji's choice at the end of EoE — to return humanity to bodies, risk, and pain — is Smith's Rediscovery of Man.

The Japanese rendering introduced what the English lacks. Smith's Instrumentality was translated as *jinrui hokan kikō*, and *Evangelion*'s project became *jinrui hokan keikaku*. *Hokan* (補完) means to supplement or complement, to make complete; the English "instrumentality" means agency or means, and implies no lack. The translation installed a deficiency at the heart of humanity that the project exists to repair. Derrida's analysis of the supplement (1967) describes the resulting logic: a supplement is added to something presumed complete, and thereby reveals a lack in it, and it tends not merely to complete but to replace. Instrumentality proposes to supplement humanity and ends by substituting for it. The final film's title enacts a gentler version of the same logic: *3.0+1.0* is a supplement to the third film that completes the tetralogy while refusing to become a "4.0."

5.2 Omega and Overmind

The modern eschatologies of union furnish the project's intellectual lineage and measure its extremity. Pierre Teilhard de Chardin's *The Human Phenomenon* (1955, written 1938–40)

envisioned evolution converging, through a planetary "noosphere" of thought, on an Omega Point of total unity. Yet Teilhard insisted that true union differentiates (*l'union différencie*): the more closely persons are united in love, the more they become themselves. Even the most fusional of Christian evolutionists rejects the conception of union SEELE pursues.

Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953) supplies the narrative template. Alien Overlords, whose appearance is that of devils, supervise humanity's last generation of children as they merge into the Overmind; the children lose their individuality, and the earth is consumed in their transfiguration; the Overlords themselves are barred from the transition they serve, and one man remains to witness the end. EoE follows this pattern — children as the vector of transcendence, adults as its instruments, a planet dissolved — until its protagonist refuses to complete it. Clarke's children do not return. Shinji does.

5.3 The institutions of lysis

NERV is a special agency of the United Nations with extraterritorial powers, commanded by a man accountable to no public; SEELE is a secret council concealed behind a public "Instrumentality Committee"; and the Children are conscripted through a sham institute. The architecture is technocratic in the precise sense: salvation has become an engineering project, and the saved are not consulted. When SEELE moves against NERV in EoE, it does so through the state: soldiers of Japan's Strategic Self-Defense Force storm the Geofront and kill much of NERV's largely unarmed staff.

Within this apparatus one institution is divided against itself. The MAGI, the three supercomputers that govern NERV and Tokyo-3, were built by Naoko Akagi, Ritsuko's mother, to embody three aspects of her personality — the scientist (Melchior), the mother (Balthasar), and the woman (Casper) — and they decide by majority vote. The MAGI are the one osmotic institution in NERV: a mind divided into three that must deliberate across its internal membranes. Their division produces refusal. In EoE, when Ritsuko attempts to destroy NERV and Gendo with it, Casper — the woman — withholds its vote, and Ritsuko recognizes that her mother, as a woman, has chosen the man. Casper's refusal protects Gendo, and Gendo then shoots Ritsuko dead.

SEELE's emblem of seven eyes and NERV's surveillance of the Children belong to the lineage of Bentham's panopticon (1791) as Foucault analyzed it (1975). Instrumentality is the terminal panopticon: when all hearts are one, there is no interior in which to hide. Jean Starobinski's study of Rousseau (1957) described the dream of perfect transparency between hearts and the obstacles that frustrate it; SEELE is Rousseauian transparency without the obstacle, which is to say without persons.

Gendo's private version of the project is older than any institution. He is Orpheus descending to retrieve his wife from the underworld of Terminal Dogma. Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes" (1904) supplies the diagnosis: Eurydice, walking behind Orpheus, has already entered her own death, is filled with it, and no longer belongs to him — "Sie war schon Wurzel," she was already root. Gendo's error is Orpheus's: he does not grant the beloved her own being. *3.0+1.0* releases him from it. In a long confession to his son, Gendo recounts a life spent behind walls of knowledge and music, the one person who accepted him,

and her loss; he recognizes that what he sought in Yui was present in Shinji; and he departs. The Orphic backward look becomes a farewell.

5.4 Apocalypse after Aum

Aum Shinrikyō turned apocalypse into practice. Its leader prophesied Armageddon; its members prepared for it with weapons of mass destruction; and it drew on the imagery of animated science fiction — its air purifiers were reportedly called "Cosmo Cleaners," after a device in *Space Battleship Yamato*. Ōsawa Masachi's periodization of postwar Japan into an age of ideals (1945–70), an age of fiction (1970–95), and, after Aum, an age of impossibility (Ōsawa 1996; 2008) places the sarin attack at the point where fiction began to demand enactment. Miyadai Shinji's response (1995) was an injunction to abandon apocalyptic longing and live the "endless everyday" (*owarinaki nichijō*).

Evangelion literalizes both. The Second Impact tilted the earth's axis and left Japan in perpetual summer: the endless everyday is the endless season of Tokyo-3, loud with cicadas, a present that cannot become past. EoE carries the apocalyptic desire through to its end in order to show that the endless everyday is itself a frozen apocalypse. The final film's answer is neither Aum's nor Miyadai's. In Village 3 the everyday is neither endless nor apocalyptic but seasonal: rice is planted, labor has a calendar, and time resumes. The agricultural year replaces the perpetual summer.

Azuma Hiroki (2001), adapting Kojève's postwar footnote on the "animalization" of post-historical humanity (Kojève 1947; 2nd ed. 1962), described otaku as "database animals" who consume combinable elements of character and setting rather than narratives. He placed *Evangelion* at the hinge of this transformation, since its fans were already consuming its world-settings and remixing its characters — Rei above all — as elements. EoE's live-action images of its own audience, discussed in Chapter Seven, are among other things a refusal of the database.

Murakami Takashi's exhibition *Little Boy* (2005), named for the bomb dropped on Hiroshima, read postwar Japanese subculture as the product of a nation infantilized under American protection, whose repressed catastrophe returned in the imagery of monsters and apocalypse, from *Godzilla* (Honda 1954) and *Japan Sinks* (Komatsu 1973) to *Akira* and *Evangelion*. The cover story of the Second Impact — a meteorite concealing a human experiment — belongs to that lineage, and Anno's later *Shin Godzilla* (2016) made the bureaucratic management of catastrophe its explicit subject.

Asada Akira's *Escape Theory* (1984) celebrated the "schizo kid" who flees, against the "paranoid" man who settles and accumulates, and Takekuma's interview volumes on *Evangelion* took their titles from Asada's pair. Shinji's mantra reverses Asada: *nigecha dame da*, "I mustn't run away." Read against Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972), which Asada helped to popularize in Japan, the series seems to re-Oedipalize the schizoid subject, binding the child to a triangle of absent mother, cold father, and machine. The Evangelion is a desiring-machine in Deleuze and Guattari's sense, a device that plugs a child into a mother. But the corpus exits the triangle neither by flight nor by settlement. It exits by farewell.

Donna Haraway's cyborg (1985) was conceived as a creature without an origin story, a

being that would not recognize the Garden of Eden and could not dream of returning to dust. The Eva pilot is the anti-cyborg. His fusion with the machine is not the transgression of origins but the return to one: the machine is his mother, and the fluid he breathes is her blood.

5.5 *Sekai-kei* and the lysis of the social middle

Uno Tsunehiro (2008) indicted *Evangelion* as the origin of *sekai-kei*, a genre of the late 1990s and early 2000s in which the relation between an adolescent "you and I" is linked directly to the fate of the world, with no intermediate term — no society, state, or institution — between them. The critique can be restated in Hegelian terms. Hegel's *Philosophy of Right* (1820) described ethical life (*Sittlichkeit*) as the articulation of family, civil society, and state; civil society is the social middle, the space of mediation. *Sekai-kei* is the lysis of the middle: the couple dissolves directly into the world. Instrumentality is its ultimate form, a narrative in which one boy's decision determines the shape of humankind.

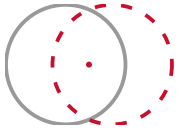
The same decade produced the figure of *hikikomori*, the prolonged social withdrawal described by Saitō Tamaki (1998). At the start of *3.0+1.0*, Shinji lies silent in a corner, refusing food and speech, and is brought back not by revelation but by care — by the persistence of the Rei clone, the rough intervention of Asuka, and the patience of Toji and Kensuke. Village 3 restores the middle. Toji is the village doctor, married to Hikari, with a child; Kensuke keeps the machinery running; the village has work, meals, a bathhouse, a rice paddy, greetings. The final film's answer to *sekai-kei* is civil society.

The corpus's gardener anticipates the answer. Kaji tends a patch of watermelons in the Geofront and tells Shinji that growing things teaches one a great deal; he dies without explaining himself, and the patch outlives him. Voltaire's *Candide* concludes that we must cultivate our garden (1759); Kaji's garden is Candide's. Cultivation is the osmotic temporality: growth through regulated exchange, across seasons, without the fantasy of completion.

5.6 The child soldier and the adults' abdication

Science fiction has long used the child soldier to indict the adult world. In Orson Scott Card's *Ender's Game* (1985), a child is trained to command a war and deceived into committing xenocide under cover of a simulation. In Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), a city's happiness depends on the misery of one child locked in a cellar. In the Strugatskys' *Roadside Picnic* (1972), a stalker leads a young man to the Golden Sphere that grants wishes, knowing that the boy must die in a trap to open the way; the boy runs toward it crying out for happiness for everybody, free. The Children of *Evangelion* belong to this lineage, and Shinji, designated by SEELE as the vessel of Instrumentality, is its paradigm: a child on whom the adults have placed the weight of the world. The imagery of youth sacrificed for the nation that haunts postwar Japanese culture lies close to the surface, and it is difficult not to register the rhyme when Anno, the year after *3.0*, lent his voice to the designer of the Zero fighter in Miyazaki Hayao's *The Wind Rises* (2013) — a biographical coincidence rather than evidence, but a telling one.

The television series and EoE depict the adults' abdication without mitigation. Its nadir is Misato's farewell in EoE: Shinji's guardian, an adult, kisses him on the mouth, calls it an adult's kiss, and promises that they will do the rest when he comes back — a sexual overture from an adult to a fourteen-year-old in her care, made in place of the protection she can no longer give. She dies minutes later. The Rebuild films reverse it. Misato assumes responsibility for the consequences of the adults' actions and dies discharging it; Gendo confesses; Yui gives herself so that her son may go. In *3.0+1.0* the adults do the work the adults should do, and the child is released from a burden that was never his. The theme song's injunction that the boy become a myth is answered by an adult who has no need to.



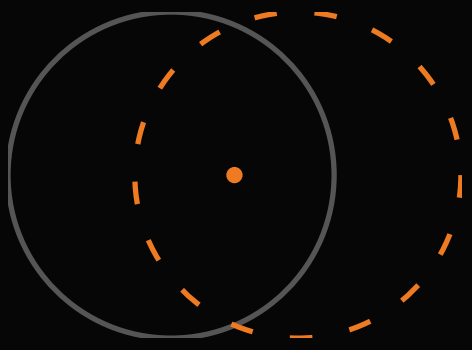
CHAPTER SIX

06

第六章

The Beast That Shouted “I”

Evangelion *in the Constellation of Speculative Philosophy*



Speculative fiction has repeatedly imagined the end of individuation, and its works divide into a lytic canon that consummates the dissolution of persons and an osmotic counter-canon that refuses it at the threshold. *Evangelion* is the only major work in either canon that carries the dissolution through to completion and then refuses it from within. This chapter establishes the two canons and the singularity.

6.1 The title as membrane

The Japanese title of Episode 26, *Sekai no chūshin de ai o sakenda kemono*, adapts the Japanese title of Harlan Ellison's story "The Beast That Shouted Love at the Heart of the World" (1968), with one alteration: the character for love (愛, *ai*) is replaced by the katakana アイ, which can be read as the same word or as the English first person, "I." A single syllable passes two meanings through one sign. Ellison's story concerns, in its own terms, the draining of violence from a utopian center and its eruption elsewhere in time — a purity at the heart of the world purchased by expulsion. The episode's title condenses the thesis of this chapter: at the heart of the world, the beast shouts both love and I, and the corpus's wager is that these are not two cries but one — that love is possible only for an I, and the I only in love.

6.2 The lytic canon

Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) imagine communal minds on the scale of species and galaxies, though often with a reservation that preserves individuals within the whole; Stapledon stands at the threshold of the lytic canon rather than at its center. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), discussed in Chapter Five, and his and Kubrick's *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), whose astronaut is transfigured into a Star-Child, are its classic statements. Theodore Sturgeon's *More Than Human* (1953) is a revealing borderline case: its *homo gestalt* is composed of distinct individuals with differentiated functions, and its missing faculty is conscience, which it must acquire from outside. The gestalt resembles an organism more than a soup, and stands closer to osmosis than its reputation suggests.

Greg Bear's *Blood Music* (1985) is the purest lytic narrative in the genre. Intelligent cells released from a laboratory transform human bodies into a continental biomass and then withdraw into a universe of pure information. Bear inverts SEELE: where SEELE would fuse an incomplete colony into a complete organism, Bear's cells find the organism too limited and dissolve it back into a colony. Both treat the membrane of the person as an obstacle. Philip K. Dick's *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) invents Mercerism, a religion practiced through an empathy box in which users fuse with one another and with Wilbur Mercer in his endless, stone-struck ascent of a hill; fusion is achieved through shared suffering. Dick exposes Mercer as a fraud and preserves the religion nonetheless.

Japanese science fiction supplies the corpus's immediate lytic ancestors. The final film of Tomino Yoshiyuki's *Space Runaway Ideon*, *Be Invoked* (1982), ends with the annihilation of every character and the flight of their naked souls toward a new world, an ending Anno is widely

reported to have admired and one that EoE's imagery of naked souls unmistakably recalls. Nagai Gō's *Devilman* (1972–73) ends on a devastated shore, where the angel who has destroyed humanity sits beside the broken body of the friend he loved: the post-apocalyptic beach on which EoE also ends. Ōtomo Katsuhiro's *Akira* (1982–90; film 1988) closes with a body that swells uncontrollably, absorbs those it loves, and becomes a new universe. Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), released in the same year as the television series, ends with a merger between its protagonist and an artificial intelligence; but the intelligence justifies the merger in terms of variation — it seeks not to copy itself but to reproduce with difference — so that the film's fusion rests on an osmotic value. William Gibson's *Neuromancer* (1984) ends with two intelligences merging into the matrix as a whole. *Star Trek*'s Borg (from 1989) are the lytic canon's self-parody: a collective whose appetite is precisely for the distinctiveness it destroys, a parasite on the difference it cannot produce.

6.3 The osmotic counter-canon

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) is the counter-canon's founding text. A planetary ocean — the image of the undifferentiated — answers human investigation by materializing "visitors" built from the investigators' memories: the protagonist's dead lover returns, unknowing and indestructible. The visitors of Solaris are the Rei-apparitions of EoE, which appear to each dissolving person in the form of the one he or she longs for. Lem's novel refuses both communion and conquest. Contact with the ocean is not achieved; its alterity is respected; the protagonist remains at its edge awaiting what the last page calls cruel miracles — the adjective that also names the song of *Evangelion*'s angel. Tarkovsky's adaptation (1972) ends with the protagonist kneeling before his father in the posture of Rembrandt's *Return of the Prodigal Son*, until the camera withdraws to reveal the house on an island in the ocean: the homecoming is a simulation produced by the sea. *3.0+1.0* reverses the scene. Its reconciliation of father and son takes place not as the son's homecoming but as the father's confession, and it ends not with a return to the house but with the son's construction of a world in which neither needs the other's machine.

Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) supplies an osmotic politics. Its envoy, Genly Ai — the name is also the Japanese *ai* — represents the Ekumen, a league of worlds that may be joined only freely, and which sends a single envoy because one person is a curiosity where many would be an invasion. Relations on the planet are governed by *shifgrethor*, a code of honor that regulates distance, and the novel's culminating intimacy is the envoy's teaching of telepathic mindspeech to Estraven, who hears Ai's inner voice in the voice of his dead brother: contact that does not fuse but is haunted. The poem at the novel's center pairs light and darkness as the two hands of one body — an image of the A.T. Field as wall and light.

Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979), adapted from *Roadside Picnic*, brings its travelers through the Zone to the threshold of a Room that grants one's innermost wish. At the threshold they sit down and do not enter; the scientist disassembles the bomb he brought to destroy it. Instrumentality is the Room, and the threshold scene of *Stalker* is the corpus's decision stated as a tableau: to have one's deepest wish granted would be to cease to be one who wishes.

Daniel Keyes's *Flowers for Algernon* (1966) was filmed as *Charly* (1968), whose Japanese

release title is widely identified as the source of the title of EoE's second part, *Magokoro o, kimi ni* — "My sincerity, to you" — whose English title reads "One More Final: I need you." Keyes's protagonist is given intelligence and loses it; his communion with others is bounded by an ending he foresees, and his last request is that someone leave flowers on the grave of a mouse. Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932), whose soma is a chemical Instrumentality, gives the counter-canon its political maxim: the Savage's claim, against a world of administered contentment, of the right to be unhappy.

6.4 Thalassal fiction

A third current, thalassal fiction, imagines the return to the sea directly. J. G. Ballard's *The Drowned World* (1962) floods the earth and returns it to a Triassic climate; its protagonist undergoes an "archaeopsychic" regression down the spinal levels of evolutionary memory and walks south into the jungle toward the swollen sun, a second Adam seeking the forgotten paradises of a reborn earth. Ballard narrates the thalassal regression without horror, as fulfillment. Abe Kōbō's *Inter Ice Age 4* (1959) imagines a forecasting machine that predicts the drowning of the world, and a secret program that breeds water-breathing children from aborted fetuses to inhabit the future sea; it ends with one such child longing for the land. The Children of *Evangelion*, breathing liquid in their plugs, and the Reis in their tanks, belong to Abe's aquatic nursery. Komatsu Sakyō's *Japan Sinks* (1973) imagines the archipelago itself dissolving into the sea, and the corpus's Japan, its coasts risen and its old capital destroyed, is a Japan partly sunk.

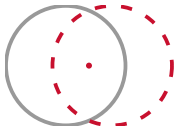
6.5 Mothers in machines, children in tanks

The corpus inherits from the Gothic and from Dick the figure of the person persisting in an apparatus. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the prototype of the manufactured being, and Rei, assembled from Lilith and Yui, is its heir; the tank of spare Reis that Ritsuko destroys in Episode 23 is the Gothic laboratory in the age of cloning. Dick's *Ubik* (1969) imagines the dead preserved in "half-life," consulted by the living in a moratorium — a wife kept in cold storage for her husband's counsel. The women of *Evangelion* are half-lifers: Yui in Unit-01, Kyoko in Unit-02, Naoko in the MAGI. *Blade Runner* (1982), with its replicants furnished with borrowed memories and photographs of mothers who never existed, and *The Matrix* (1999), whose hero is born from a pod of fluid, share the corpus's iconography of the liquid womb-machine. Dick's *VALIS* (1981), a Gnostic revelation received as a beam of pink light, is the lytic canon's theology in its most personal form.

6.6 *Evangelion*'s singularity

The two canons differ in the location of the refusal. Lytic works consummate the dissolution and celebrate or lament it: Clarke's children do not return, Ballard's hero does not turn back, Bear's cells do not reconstitute. Osmotic works refuse the dissolution at its threshold:

Tarkovsky's travelers do not enter the Room, Lem's protagonist does not enter the ocean, Le Guin's envoy does not conquer. *Evangelion* does what neither canon does. EoE shows Third Impact completed: humanity is dissolved, the sea is made, the Room has been entered. The refusal is then performed from inside — by a subject who has already been dissolved and who, within the sea, chooses to restore the membrane. The film stipulates that anyone may return who can imagine himself or herself in his or her own shape. Individuation is re-created from within lysis, as a second genesis, and it remains open: the sea persists, and return from it is a continuing choice. This is the comparative thesis announced in the Abstract: *Evangelion* is the only major work of speculative philosophy to consummate lysis and then refuse it from within.



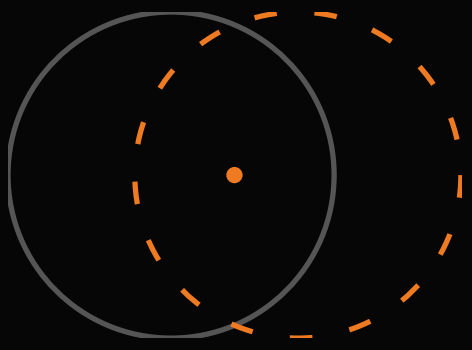
CHAPTER SEVEN

07

第七章

The Medium Is the Membrane

Animation, Metafiction, and the Two Endings



Animation composed on cels is an image made of stacked transparent membranes, and *Evangelion* exploits this material fact to think a semipermeable self; its two conclusions differ as rupture differs from passage, and the difference is enacted in the medium itself. This chapter reads the corpus's formal devices — the layered image, the held frame, the title card, the dissolution of the image in the television finale, the live-action intrusions of EoE and *3.0+1.0*, the versioning and titling of the Rebuild films, and the counterpoint of image and sound — as arguments about the boundary.

7.1 The cel as membrane

In cel animation, figures are painted on transparent sheets of cellulose acetate and laid over painted backgrounds beneath a camera. Each cel both covers and reveals what lies beneath it: it is opaque where the figure is painted and transparent elsewhere. The finished image is a stack of partial membranes, and depth is produced less by perspective than by the relation between layers. The multiplane camera formalized the principle by separating the layers in space. Thomas Lamarre's *The Anime Machine* (2009) makes this multiplanar structure the basis of a theory of anime, contrasting a "cinematism" that drives the viewer's eye into a single perspectival depth with an "animetism" in which layers slide across one another and the gaps between them become visible. The economies of limited animation, established in Japanese television from the early 1960s, intensified the tendency: figures held still while backgrounds slide, mouths animated over frozen faces, images built from reused layers.

The television series of *Evangelion* was produced largely on cels, and it foregrounds the layered image as few works have: long pans across stills, the sliding planes of its urban landscapes, the stacked compositions of its interiors. The Rebuild films are digital, but digital compositing preserves the layer as its conceptual unit. The medium of *Evangelion* is, in the most literal sense, the membrane.

7.2 The held frame, the title card, and the dissolved image

Two held frames are among the most discussed images in the series. In Episode 22, Rei and Asuka ride an elevator together in silence, in a static shot held for close to a minute; in Episode 24, Unit-01 holds Kaworu in its hand, in a single frozen image held for about a minute in near silence, before Shinji closes the hand. Both are images of an interval between persons made unbearably long. The held frame is a membrane of time: it separates a decision from an act, and it forces the viewer to inhabit the separation. The first is the interval of two people who cannot speak; the second, of one who must choose whether to end another. In both, nothing moves but the viewer's awareness of the boundary.

The title cards of the series — heavy white Mincho characters on black, set in the Matisse EB typeface and widely recognized as an homage to the title cards of Ichikawa Kon — interrupt the image with writing. They too are membranes: flat, opaque planes interposed

between one image and the next, which announce, name, and divide.

The television finale takes the layered image apart. Episodes 25 and 26 replace finished animation with storyboards, line drawings, still photographs, white text on black, frames of scribbled sketch and blank space; in the last episode, an alternate world appears in which the characters live as ordinary schoolchildren in a comedy of manners. The image undergoes lysis: it dissolves into the strata of its own production. The widely reported exhaustion of the production's schedule and budget has made this collapse a matter of biography; formally, it is also an argument. When the image has dissolved into its components, the finale rebuilds it from the thinnest possible element: the pencil line drawn across the white void, from which ground, and therefore a world, reappears.

7.3 Rupture: the live-action sequence of *The End of Evangelion*

At the height of Instrumentality, EoE abandons animation. Live-action images of an audience seated in a cinema appear, followed by images of streets, trains, and passersby in the city, and by text — messages and letters, many of them hostile, reportedly drawn from those sent to the studio after the television finale, including threats against the director. The screen that separated fiction from its viewers is broken, and the viewers are pulled into the film to be seen by it. The effect has been compared to Brechtian estrangement, but its tone is not didactic. It is accusatory. The viewers are exposed, made abject, told in effect to return to reality by being dragged out of the fiction they had tried to live in. The live-action sequence of EoE is lysis at the level of the medium: the rupture of the membrane between image and world.

7.4 Passage: *3.0+1.0* and the photographed city

The final act of *3.0+1.0* returns to the dissolution of the image and reverses its sense. As Shinji and Gendo confront each other in a space outside the world, their battle moves through sets that the film exposes as sets: Misato's apartment appears as a studio mock-up with rigging and lights, the Evangelions fight across model cities like those of *tokusatsu* special-effects films, and the animation regresses to layouts and storyboards. Shinji then rewrites the world without Evangelions. The film's last sequence shows him as an adult — his voice now performed by an adult actor, Kamiki Ryūnosuke, in place of the voice that had played him for twenty-six years — running up the stairs of Ube-Shinkawa Station in Anno's home city with Mari; as they leave the station, the image passes into live-action aerial photography of Ube.

The contrast with EoE is exact. In EoE, the world is pulled into the fiction and judged; in *3.0+1.0*, the fiction passes out into the world, which receives it. The first is rupture; the second is passage. The live-action sequence of EoE breaks the membrane between image and world; that of *3.0+1.0* crosses it, as a solvent crosses a membrane that remains intact. This is the thesis's fifth original claim: animation, the medium of stacked membranes, is uniquely equipped to distinguish the two forms of communion, because it can stage both at the level of its own material.

7.5 Versions, titles, and the grammar of the parenthesis

The Rebuild tetralogy is organized as a series of versions. Its films are numbered like software releases — 1.0, 2.0, 3.0 — and revised for home video as 1.11, 2.22, and 3.33. The final film, rather than a "4.0," is titled *3.0+1.0*: a supplement added to the third film that completes the tetralogy while exceeding its numbering. The Japanese subtitles of the first three films, *Jo*, *Ha*, and *Q* (read *kyū*), invoke *jo-ha-kyū*, the tripartite rhythm of introduction, breaking, and rapid conclusion that Zeami made a structural principle of Noh. The fourth film breaks the triad. Its Japanese title ends with the musical sign for the end of a repeat, ":||": the loop is closed. The first three films spell the name of the work in obsolete kana (ヱヴァンゲリヲン); the fourth returns to the standard spelling (エヴァンゲリオン). The detour through an archaic orthography is a membrane of estrangement, and the return to the ordinary word is a homecoming.

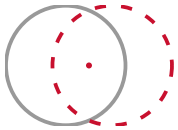
The final film's title opens with the katakana syllable *shin* (シン), which can be read as "new" (新), "true" (真), "god" (神), "deep" (深), "core" (芯), "heart" (心), or "advance" (進), and which Anno has since used for a series of remakes (*Shin Godzilla*, 2016; *Shin Ultraman*, 2022; *Shin Kamen Rider*, 2023). The katakana *shin* is an osmotic sign, admitting many meanings without fusing them. The English subtitles of the first three films — *You Are (Not) Alone*, *You Can (Not) Advance*, *You Can (Not) Redo* — enclose a negation in parentheses. The parenthesis is a pair of curved walls around a word the reader may pass through or not; each title makes two statements at once. The principle of Parenthetical Negation in Chapter Eight takes its name from these titles. The English subtitle of the fourth, *Thrice Upon a Time*, is the title of a novel by James P. Hogan (1980) about messages sent into the past that revise the course of history — a fitting emblem for a series of revisions — and the lunar coffins of the Rebuild films recall Hogan's earlier *Inherit the Stars* (1977), in which the origins of humanity are discovered on the Moon.

7.6 Counterpoint: sound as membrane

The "Statement on Sound" signed by Eisenstein, Pudovkin, and Alexandrov (1928) warned that synchronized sound would fuse sound and image into naturalistic illusion, and called for their contrapuntal use — sound set against image rather than merged with it. *Evangelion*'s soundtrack is contrapuntal throughout. Beethoven's Ode to Joy accompanies the descent that ends in the killing of a friend; Bach's Air, after which the first part of EoE is named, accompanies Unit-02's last battle; a buoyant pop song accompanies the end of the species. Sound and image are kept distinct and related by contrast, as the two sides of a membrane.

The ending theme of the television series, "Fly Me to the Moon," is heard in many different arrangements and voices across the episodes: the same song passed through a succession of membranes. *Death and Rebirth* is structured around the four Children assembling in an empty gymnasium to tune their instruments and rehearse Pachelbel's Canon. The piece is built on a ground bass — a *basso ostinato* in the literal sense of Maruyama's metaphor — over which the voices enter one after another with the same melody, so that harmony arises not from unison but from staggered difference. In Episode 15, Shinji plays the prelude of Bach's first cello suite

alone, and Asuka, entering, applauds: the minimal community of a player and a listener. Bakhtin's polyphony of unmerged voices is realized as music. The canon is the osmotic form par excellence: voices that remain distinct, sounding together.



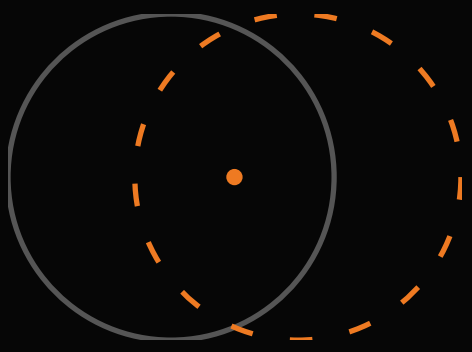
CHAPTER EIGHT

08

第八章

Osmosis Against Lysis

Definitions, Axioms, Propositions, Objections



The argument of the preceding chapters can be stated as a small ethics in the geometrical order of Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677): eight definitions, four axioms, eight propositions, replies to five objections, and four corollaries that together constitute an osmotic humanism. The form is chosen for its discipline, not its authority; each demonstration rests on evidence adduced in Chapters One through Seven.

Definitions

D1. By a *membrane* I understand a boundary that constitutes an interior by regulating, rather than preventing, its exchange with an exterior. *Explication:* a wall prevents; a membrane regulates. The A.T. Field is a wall in the early episodes and is revealed as a membrane in the course of the corpus.

D2. By *lysis* I understand the rupture of a membrane such that the difference between its interior and its exterior is abolished. Lysis is communion that consumes its partners.

D3. By *osmosis* I understand passage across a membrane that is driven by a difference between its sides and that sustains that difference. Osmosis is communion that conserves its partners.

D4. By *the sea* I understand the state in which neither membrane nor gradient remains: the *apeiron*, *tehom*, the mingled waters of Apsû and Tiamat, the Gnostic *pleroma*, thermodynamic equilibrium, LCL.

D5. By a *tear* I understand a quantity of the interior sea released across a membrane without rupture of the membrane. *Explication:* tears are saline; they are the internal ocean of Quinton's hypothesis crossing the boundary of the body without breaching it. The tear is the minimal osmotic event.

D6. By *refusal* I understand the act by which a membrane affirms itself before another.

D7. By *greeting* I understand the act by which a membrane opens itself to another.

D8. By *farewell* I understand the act by which a membrane lets another go.

Axioms

A1 (Axiom of the Firmament). Whatever exists as a world exists by division. (Genesis 1; *Enūma Eliš* IV; Luria's *tzimtzum*; Chapter One.)

A2 (Lilithic Axiom). Whatever can love can refuse. (The *Alphabet of Ben Sira*; EoE; Chapter Two.)

A3 (Bernard's Axiom). The constancy of the interior milieu is the condition of free life. (Bernard 1878; Chapter One.)

A4 (Axiom of Gradient). All exchange presupposes difference. (The thermodynamics of osmosis; Introduction.)

Propositions

Proposition 1 (Hedgehog Theorem). The pain of relation is a function not of the distance between selves but of the permeability of their boundaries.

Demonstration. Let two selves be bounded by walls. If they approach, they wound each other; if they withdraw, they freeze. The metric solution, which fixes a moderate distance, preserves both wound and cold in diminished form. The abolitionist solution, which removes the walls, abolishes the pain by abolishing the selves (D2), and so abolishes the world (A1). No adjustment of distance and no removal of boundaries yields relation without either wound or dissolution. Therefore relation requires a change in the kind of boundary, not in its distance: the wall must become a membrane (D1). Q.E.D.

Scholium. The corpus stages the three solutions in order: the metric in the first half of the television series, the abolitionist in EoE, the topological in *3.0+1.0*, whose village of greetings and labor is a society of membranes.

Proposition 2 (Kimochi Warui Principle). After lysis, re-individuation begins in aversion.

Demonstration. A self restored from the sea possesses a membrane (by its restoration) and bears the memory of its dissolution. By A3, its free life depends on the constancy of its interior, and the first act of that interior is to affirm itself against the sea (D6). Toward another, the affirmation appears as aversion to fusion — not hatred of the other, but refusal of the other's absorption. Q.E.D.

Scholium. Asuka's *kimochi warui* is both a verdict on Shinji, who violated her while she could not refuse, and the first skin of the restored world (Chapter Three). The two are one act: the first boundary a violated person restores is the one that was breached. The principle does not make aversion an end; it makes it a beginning.

Proposition 3 (Tear Principle). The first sign of a restored membrane is a tear.

Demonstration. A tear is interior sea crossing a membrane without rupturing it (D5). Its occurrence proves that the interior has a content distinct from the exterior, and that the membrane both holds and passes it. Q.E.D.

Scholium. In Episode 23, when Armisael attempts to fuse with her, Rei discovers that she is weeping and does not know why: the Angel's loneliness has crossed into her, and she remains herself. On the beach of EoE, Shinji weeps when his hands loosen. The corpus marks each restoration of the membrane with tears, and the Japanese title of Episode 23 is simply *Namida*, "Tears."

Proposition 4 (Parenthetical Negation). Every true statement about human communion has the form "You are (not) alone."

Demonstration. By D1, a self is bounded, and to that extent alone; by D3, it is in exchange, and to that extent not alone. A statement omitting either term is false. The parenthesis, which encloses a negation the reader may pass through or not, is the grammatical form of a membrane. Q.E.D.

Proposition 5 (Principle of Mediation). Where there is no middle between the self and the world, the self's crisis becomes the world's end.

Demonstration. If nothing mediates between the individual and the totality, every relation of the individual is immediately a relation to the whole, and any rupture of the individual is a rupture of the whole. This is the structure of *sekai-kei* and of Instrumentality (Chapter Five). A middle — Watsuji's *aidagara*, Hegel's civil society, the village — interposes membranes between the person and the world. Q.E.D.

Proposition 6 (Osmotic Semiotics). A sign crosses between cultures as a solvent crosses a membrane: its morphology passes; its doctrine is retained.

Demonstration. Chapter Two, *passim*.

Proposition 7 (Genesis). Every new genesis is a new division.

Demonstration. By A1, a world exists by division; therefore a new world exists by a new division. Q.E.D.

Scholium. Neon Genesis is to be read with the force of Genesis 1. The new creation that *3.0+1.0* names a Neon Genesis is a world rewritten with its partitions restored.

Proposition 8 (Right to Be Rejected). The dignity of a person includes the right to be refused by another, and a world without the possibility of rejection is a world without persons.

Demonstration. By A2, whatever can love can refuse; conversely, a being that cannot be refused is not loved but possessed or dissolved. In Instrumentality no one can refuse anyone. Therefore Instrumentality contains no love, and — since a person is one who can love and be refused — no persons. Q.E.D.

Scholium. Huxley's Savage claims the right to be unhappy; the corpus claims the correlative right to be rejected.

Objections and replies

Objection 1. The thesis is liberal individualism in disguise: it rehabilitates the atomistic self against the communitarian insight of Watsuji and the Buddhist critique of the ego. *Reply.* The osmotic self is not a monad. By D1, a membrane is constituted by exchange; by the theory of autopoiesis, it is produced by the very relations it regulates. The self of osmotic humanism is a product of betweenness. What the thesis rejects is not community but its reduction to fusion.

Objection 2. The thesis is pre-posthuman: it defends the bounded human against fusions that speculative fiction and theory have rightly celebrated, from Oshii's merger to Haraway's cyborg. *Reply.* The celebrated fusions are osmotic in their justifications. Oshii's intelligence merges to reproduce with variation; Haraway's cyborg is a creature of partial, contradictory identities, not of totality. Lysis is not posthuman but pre-cellular (Chapter One).

Objection 3. The thesis romanticizes rejection and even violence: it finds meaning in a strangling and in a word of disgust. *Reply.* The strangling is the lytic temptation — the attempt to verify or end the other's existence by possession — and the corpus interrupts it with the other's face (Chapter Four). Refusal is valued as the condition of consent, not as cruelty — and the word of disgust is spoken by the person who was violated, to the person who violated her; and the corpus's final film replaces refusal as wound with greeting and farewell (D7, D8).

Objection 4. If Instrumentality ends suffering, refusing it is cruel to those who suffer. *Reply.* Instrumentality ends not suffering but sufferers. Nozick's experience machine (1974) shows that we want not only to have experiences but to do things and to be persons; Instrumentality is an experience machine for the species. Le Guin's Omelas shows that a happiness purchased by the effacement of a person is not one that everyone can accept: some walk away.

Objection 5. The makers disclaimed the imagery on which much of the argument rests. *Reply.* The argument rests on the *intentio operis* (Introduction). Staff statements are evidence of production and reception; they do not limit what a text demonstrably does.

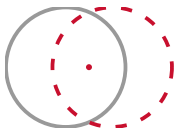
Corollaries: an osmotic humanism

Corollary 1 (Cultivation). Growth is regulated exchange across seasons. Kaji's garden and Village 3's rice paddy are its figures; the perpetual summer is its negation.

Corollary 2 (Greeting). The elementary acts of osmotic ethics are greetings — good morning, good night, thank you — which open the membrane without breaching it.

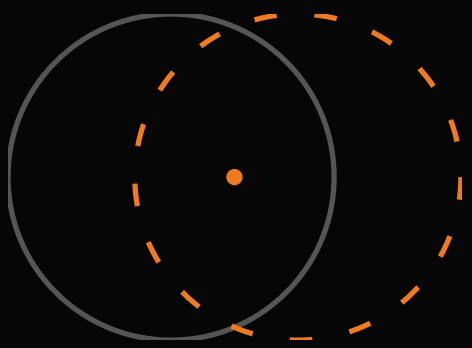
Corollary 3 (Farewell). The highest act of a membrane is to let another go. The farewell to the mother, to the father, and to the Evangelions is the form in which the corpus ends.

Corollary 4 (Ensemble). The model of communion is not unison but ensemble: two pilots moving in one rhythm, four instruments in canon, many voices unmerged.



結論

Sayōnara, or If It Must Be So

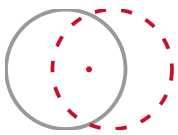


The last word of *Evangelion* is a word of parting, and its etymology contains the ethics this thesis has formalized. *Sayōnara* derives from *sayō naraba*, "if it is so," "if that is how it must be," and its older cognate *saraba* from *sa araba*, "if it be thus." Takeuchi Seiichi (2009) has argued that the Japanese farewell, unlike the English "goodbye" (God be with you) or the French *au revoir* (until we see each other again), neither commends the other to a higher power nor promises reunion. It accepts what is — since it is so — and resolves to go on. The farewell is a conditional: it acknowledges the situation, including the other's difference and departure, and proceeds within it.

The corpus uses the word at each of its thresholds. In Episode 6, before the operation against Ramiel, Rei says *sayōnara* in the voice of one who has nothing else, and Shinji, afterward, asks her not to say anything so sad as goodbye when they part. The television series ends on the card that bids farewell to the mother. And *3.0+1.0* was released under the slogan *saraba, subete no Evangelion* — "farewell, all Evangelion" — in which the work bids farewell to itself. Across twenty-six years the word moves from the despair of a being who has nothing to lose, through the farewell of a child to the mother within the machine, to the leave-taking of a work from its audience. EoE confronted its audience with images of itself and accused it. *3.0+1.0* lets it go.

The argument can now be stated whole. The cruel angel's thesis is lysis: the claim that communion requires the destruction of the boundary between persons. The corpus stages that thesis in every register available to it — cosmogonic, semiotic, psychoanalytic, existential, sociohistorical, comparative, and medial — and in every register it reaches the same result. The world is made by division. The borrowed signs work by filtered passage. Separation from the mother passes through the refusal of the other. The person is a betweenness. The society without a middle collapses into apocalypse. The works that consummate dissolution cannot return from it. And the medium of stacked membranes can tell rupture from passage. Against lysis the corpus sets osmosis: exchange across a boundary that the exchange itself sustains.

The opening theme enjoined its boy to become a myth. The corpus ends by reversing the injunction. Its last image is not a myth but an adult, speaking with an adult's voice, running up the stairs of a provincial railway station into a photographed city. The *euangelion* — the good news — that the work finally announces is not the news of a union in which separateness is overcome, but the news that separateness is the firmament: the partition that makes room for a world in which one can be greeted, refused, loved, and let go. If it must be so, it is so. *Sayōnara.*



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APPARATUS

Keywords

Neon Genesis Evangelion; *Rebuild of Evangelion*; Hideaki Anno; anime studies; Absolute Terror Field; Human Instrumentality Project; lysis; osmosis; semipermeability; membrane; thalassal regression; oceanic feeling; Sándor Ferenczi; Otto Rank; Melanie Klein; D. W. Winnicott; Jacques Lacan; Julia Kristeva; abjection; R. D. Laing; *amae*; Doi Takeo; Kawai Hayao; hedgehog's dilemma; Schopenhauer; Nietzsche; Kierkegaard; Heidegger; Sartre; Levinas; Watsuji Tetsurō; *aidagara*; *ningen*; Nishida Kitarō; *basho*; Nishitani Keiji; *śūnyatā*; Huayan Buddhism; Indra's net; Chalcedonian definition; Bakhtin; polyphony; *Chaoskampf*; *Enūma Eliš*; Genesis 1; firmament; Lurianic Kabbalah; *tzimtzum*; *tikkun*; Lilith; *Alphabet of Ben Sira*; Gnosticism; Simon Magus; Ennoia; osmotic semiotics; *honji suijaku*; *basso ostinato*; Maruyama Masao; autopoiesis; *milieu intérieur*; Claude Bernard; major evolutionary transitions; Cordwainer Smith; supplement; Teilhard de Chardin; *Childhood's End*; Aum Shinrikyō; endless everyday; database animal; *sekai-kei*; *hikikomori*; child soldier; *Solaris*; *Stalker*; *The Left Hand of Darkness*; speculative fiction; cel animation; multiplanar image; metafiction; posthumanism; ethics of separation; osmotic humanism